



CITY: Pg 3

Transgender residents can avail free travel on DTC, cluster buses



NATION: Pg 5

Oppn attacks govt on West Asia crisis



FILM: Pg 14

'One Battle After Another' triumphs at 98th Academy Awards

TRUMP CALLS FOR HELP TO REOPEN STRAIT OF HORMUZ

Fears of global energy crisis rise as Iran keeps stranglehold on shipping



Fire and plumes of smoke rises after s drone struck a fuel tank forcing the temporary suspension of flights. near Dubai International Airport

ASSOCIATED PRESS

BEIRUT: Fears of a global energy crisis rose on Monday as the war in the Middle East raged on, with more US-Israeli strikes on the Iranian capital and Israel's bombardment of Lebanon. An Iranian drone strike temporarily shut Dubai's airport, a crucial global travel hub, underscoring the threats to the world economy. Since the US and Israel attacked Iran more than two weeks ago, Tehran has regularly fired on Israel, American bases in the region, and Gulf Arab countries' energy infrastructure with drones and missiles. Iranian strikes on commercial ships in and around the Strait of Hormuz and even just the threat of those attacks have also effectively stopped shipping traffic in the vital waterway, through which a fifth of the world's oil is transported. That has dramatically increased the price of oil and put pressure on Washington to do some-

CLOSER LOOK

- » Iranian drone strike briefly shut Dubai International Airport
- » Saudi Arabia intercepted 35 Iranian drones targeting its eastern oil-producing region
- » Iran has fired hundreds of missiles and drones at Israel, US bases, and Gulf infrastructure

- » Attacks on ships and threats around the Strait of Hormuz halted most shipping traffic
- » The strait carries about one-fifth of global oil, amplifying fears of supply disruption
- » Brent crude rose above \$100 a barrel, up about 45% since the Feb. 28 strikes

thing to ease the pain for consumers. Brent crude, the international standard, remained stubbornly over USD 100 a barrel on Monday. It was at USD 104 in early trading, up nearly 45 per cent since the US and Israel attacked Iran on Feb. 28. It has spiked as high as about USD 120 during the conflict. US President Donald Trump said he has demanded that about seven countries send warships to keep the Strait of Hormuz open, but his appeals have brought no commitments. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi called claims that his country may be seeking a negotiated end to the war "delusional," saying in a social media post early Monday that Iran was seeking neither "truce nor talks." As morning broke on Monday, a drone hit a fuel tank near Dubai International Airport, the world's busiest for international passenger traffic, causing a large fire.

Continued on P4

Nitish Kumar and Nitin Nabin elected to Rajya Sabha from Bihar

Voting held for 11 of 37 vacancies; 26 candidates elected unopposed

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: The ruling National Democratic Alliance secured a decisive outcome in the latest Rajya Sabha elections across several states, winning the majority of contested seats and strengthening its numbers in the Upper House of Parliament. Results declared on Monday showed the NDA capturing eight of the 11 seats where voting took place in Bihar, Odisha and Haryana, while the Biju Janata Dal secured one seat. Counting in Haryana was halted following complaints about violations of ballot secrecy.

The elections were held for 11 seats out of a total of 37 Rajya Sabha vacancies, as 26 candidates had already been elected unopposed earlier this month after withdrawals left them without challengers. Among those chosen without contest on March 9 were Nationalist



KEY POINTS

- » Bihar NDA swept all five seats, including victories for Nitish Kumar and BJP president Nitin Nabin.
- » Ram Nath Thakur and Upendra Kushwaha were re-elected, while BJP's Shivesh Kumar entered Rajya Sabha for first time
- » Oppn Mahagathbandhan faltered as three Congress and one RJD MLA were absent during voting

Congress Party (SP) chief Sharad Pawar and Union minister Ramdas Athawale. In Bihar, the NDA swept all five seats in a contest that saw 14 candidates across states

competing for the available positions. Chief Minister Nitish Kumar of the Janata Dal (United) and newly appointed Bharatiya Janata Party president Nitin Nabin were elected from the state. Union minister Ram Nath Thakur of the JD(U) and Rashtriya Lok Morcha leader Upendra Kushwaha were also re-elected, while BJP nominee Shivesh Kumar secured a Rajya Sabha berth for the first time. Alliance leaders claimed strong participation from their legislators during the vote. Sources within the NDA said all 202 MLAs belonging to the alliance participated in the polling. The bloc includes the JD(U), the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) led by Union minister Chirag Paswan, the Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) headed by Jitan Ram Manjhi and Kushwaha's Rashtriya Lok Morcha.

Continued on P4

CRISIS AT STRAIT OF HORMUZ

India denies talks with US on sending warships

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Monday said it has not held bilateral discussions with the United States about sending naval vessels to secure merchant shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, even as tensions in West Asia continue to disrupt energy supplies and maritime movement in one of the world's most critical trade routes. The clarification came amid a wider international debate over safeguarding the strategic waterway after Iran's actions effectively restricted traffic through the strait, which carries about one-fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas shipments. At the same time, New Delhi is managing evacuations of its citizens from Iran and working to ensure the safe movement of Indian-flagged vessels stranded in the region. Addressing questions during a weekly media briefing, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India has not held any bilateral consultations with



FILE PHOTO

HIGHLIGHTS

- » LPG-laden ship to reach India on Tuesday; 22 Indian vessels yet to cross Strait of Hormuz
- » India evacuates over 550 nationals from Iran; Jaishankar thanks Armenia for transit support
- » India asks its citizens not to cross Iran's border without coordination with embassy
- » Jaishankar says no blanket arrangement with Iran for transit of Indian-flagged ships through Hormuz

Washington regarding the deployment of Indian warships to the region. "We are aware of this particular matter being discussed by several countries. We have not yet discussed it in a bilateral setting," Jaiswal said, adding that India would continue

consultations with various stakeholders on the issue. The remarks came after a call by US President Donald Trump urging several nations to contribute naval forces to keep the Strait of Hormuz open. In a post on his Truth Social platform, Trump said

he hoped countries including China, France, Japan, South Korea and the United Kingdom would dispatch warships to ensure the shipping route remains "safe and open". However, there have been no immediate commitments from the countries mentioned. The Strait, a narrow maritime passage linking the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman, has become a focal point of the ongoing conflict in the region after US and Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28 and Tehran's subsequent retaliation. The disruption has pushed up global oil and gas prices and complicated the movement of cargo vessels through the waterway. India, which relies heavily on imports for its energy needs, is particularly exposed to disruptions in Gulf shipping lanes. The country imports about 88 per cent of its crude oil, around 50 per cent of its natural gas and about 60 per cent of its liquefied petroleum gas requirements.

Continued on P4

RESHUFFLES TOP POLICE POSTS

EC removes Bengal Chief & Home Secys

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Hours after the announcement of the election schedule, the Election Commission of India (ECI) ordered a sweeping administrative reshuffle in West Ben-

gal, directing the immediate removal of the state's Chief Secretary and Home Secretary and replacing the Director General of Police (DGP), the Commissioner of Kolkata Police and several other senior officers.

The Commission said the two IAS officers removed from the top administrative posts should not be assigned any election-related duty till the completion of the poll process. The move is aimed at ensuring administrative

neutrality and smooth conduct of the elections. The state government was asked to appoint new officers to the key administrative posts and directed that the changes be implemented immediately.

Continued on P4

SC quashes criminal proceedings against Ashoka University professor

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday closed criminal proceedings against Ashoka University professor Ali Khan Mahmudabad after the Haryana government, informed the court that it had decided not to grant sanction for his prosecution over social media posts related to "Operation Sindoor". The deci-

sion came after the state told the court it was declining sanction as a "one-time magnanimity", effectively bringing the case pending before the trial court to an end. Appearing for the Haryana government, Additional Solicitor General S V Raju told a bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joyymalya Bagchi that the state

Continued on P4

Fire at Cuttack hospital ICU kills 10 patients

CM forms fact-finding team

MPOST BUREAU

BHUBANESWAR: At least 10 patients died after a major fire broke out in the intensive care unit of the state-run SCB Medical College and Hospital in Odisha's Cuttack early Monday, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi said. The blaze erupted in the Trauma Care ICU between 2.30 am and 3 am, when critically ill

patients were undergoing treatment. According to Majhi, there were 23 patients admitted in the Trauma Care ICU along with an adjacent ICU and ward at the time of the incident. Seven patients died in the fire, while three others later succumbed to burn injuries or suffocation during evacuation, the chief minister said. About 11 hospital staff members suffered burn

Continued on P4

UAE orders arrests of 19 Indians for misleading content

DUBAI: The United Arab Emirates has ordered the arrest of 35 individuals, including 19 Indian nationals, for allegedly publishing misleading and fabricated content on social media during a period of heightened regional tensions, according to the official Emirates News Agency (WAM). The UAE Attorney General, Dr Hamad Saif Al Shamsi, directed that the suspects be referred for expedited trial following an investigation triggered by increased monitoring of digital platforms. Authorities said the surveillance aimed

Continued on P4

AGREEMENT WAS EARLIER EXPECTED TO BE SIGNED IN MARCH

India-US trade agreement awaits clarity on new tariff architecture

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The interim trade agreement between India and the United States will be signed once Washington finalises its new global tariff structure, a senior government official said on Monday, indicating that both sides are waiting for clarity on the evolving tariff regime before formally concluding the pact. India and the United States last month announced that they had finalised the framework for the first phase of a bilateral trade agreement. Under the arrangement, the United States agreed to reduce tariffs on Indian goods to 18 per cent, a rate that was lower



» MEETING OF CHIEF NEGOTIATORS POSTPONED DUE TO UNCERTAINTY OVER THE NEW US TARIFF STRUCTURE

than those applied to several competing economies. However, developments in the US legal and policy framework have altered the timeline for signing the agreement.

TAKEAWAYS

- » Timeline changed after US Supreme Court ruling against tariffs imposed under the IEEPA
- » Following the ruling, US imposed 10 percent tariffs on all countries for 150 days from February 24

A ruling by the US Supreme Court against sweeping tariffs introduced by President Donald Trump led to changes in the tariff system.

Continued on P4



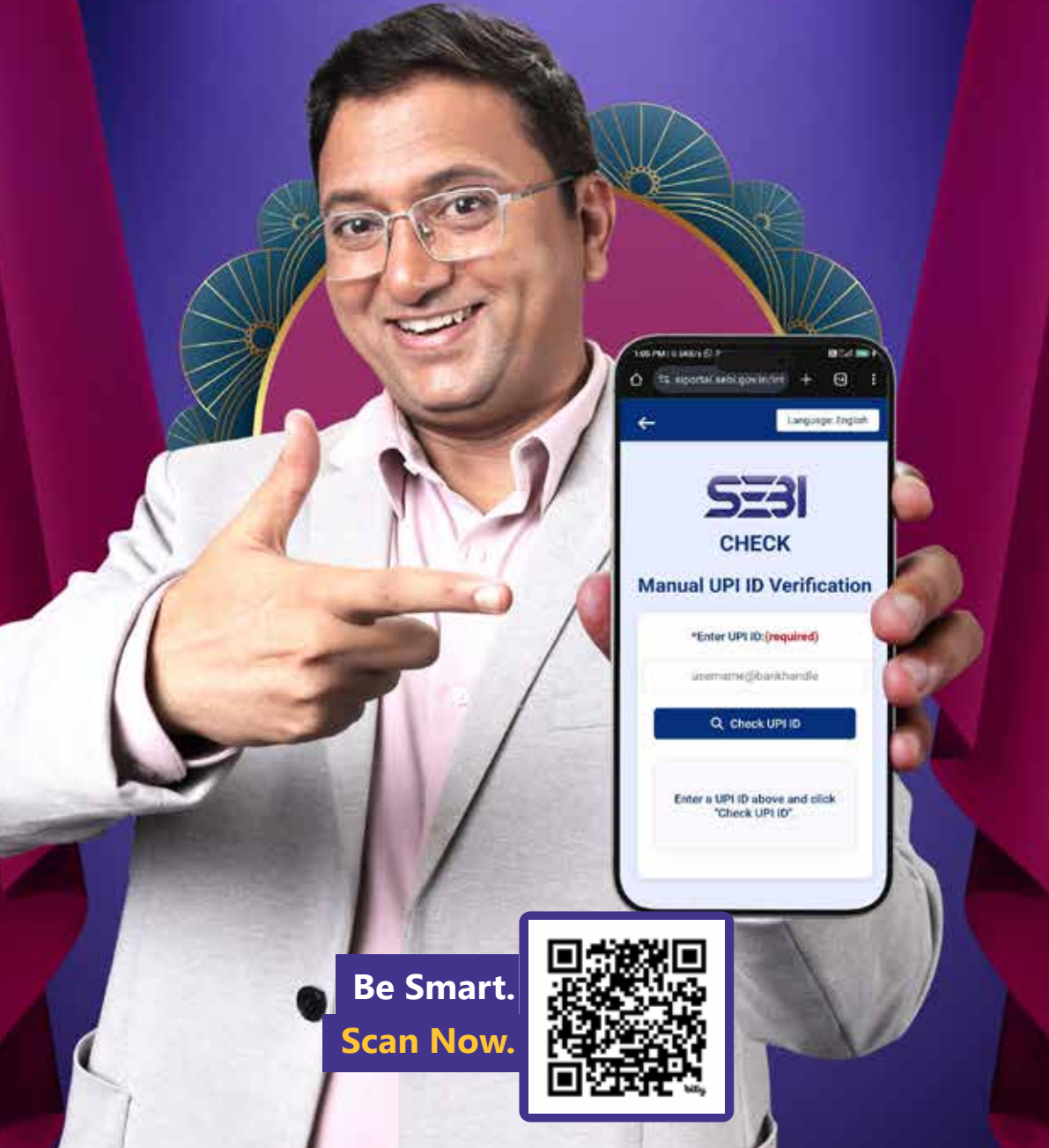
सहकारी प्रतिष्ठान और निवेशक बोर्ड
Securities and Exchange Board of India



NSE
IPFT

PAYMENT TAB KARO
JAB SEBICHECK KARO

SEBI INTRODUCES "VALIDATED UPI HANDLES"
TO ENABLE SECURED PAYMENTS



Be Smart.
Scan Now.



Download the Saaṛthi App
#SEBICheck

NO SUICIDE NOTE FOUND

Man jumps with toddler from 23rd floor of tower in Ggm; both killed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A private school operator allegedly jumped from the 23rd floor of a residential building with his two-year-old daughter in his arms here on Monday, killing both, police said.

Police said Rahul Vijayran (35), from Delhi's Nangloi area, lived in Tower 9 of the residential society, but he jumped from another tower, which makes the case suspicious.

According to Vijayran's family members, he had lost his sight in one eye after contracting coronavirus during the COVID-19 pandemic and was distressed due to this.

The incident took place at a housing society in Sector 102 around 7.30 am.

On Monday morning, while Neetu Dahiya was cooking at home, her husband Vijayran took their daughter Vamika to



“The cause behind suicide is yet to be ascertained; no suicide note was found. We are probing why he jumped from another tower”

play in the society park.

He later went to the 23rd floor of Tower 5 and allegedly jumped with his child, police said.

Upon hearing commotion, when Neetu went out, she

KEY POINTS

» On Monday morning, while Neetu Dahiya was cooking at home, her husband Vijayran took their daughter Vamika to play in the society park. He later went to the 23rd floor of Tower 5 and allegedly jumped with his child, police said

» Upon hearing commotion, when she went out, she found a man and a girl lying on the ground in a pool of blood: Cops

found a man and a girl lying on the ground in a pool of blood. Residents took the two to a private hospital, where doctors declared them dead.

Vijayaran's brother, Amit, told police that his brother

got married in 2014.

The couple also has an 11-year-old daughter who studies in Dehradun and lives in a hostel there.

Amit also told the police that his brother had been living in the society for the past two months, and he runs a school in Delhi's Kirari.

“My brother's eyes were damaged when he contracted coronavirus, causing him to lose vision in one eye and have limited vision in the other. He was deeply distressed because of this, pushing him to eventually take this step”, he added. Sub Inspector Jagmal Singh said that the family has refused to take any action.

“The cause behind the suicide is yet to be ascertained, and no suicide note was found. We are investigating why he jumped from another tower. Further probe is underway”, the officer said.

26-yr-old jumps to death from Ambience Mall

GURUGRAM: A 26-year-old man allegedly died by suicide after jumping from the third floor of Ambience Mall on Sunday around 3 pm.

Dishant, a native of Muzaffarnagar in Uttar Pradesh, had gone to the mall and was seen standing near a food outlet where he had eaten before crossing the railing and jumping. Mall staff rushed him to a nearby private hospital, where he died during treatment. Police from DLF Phase 3 station reached the spot and informed his family. No suicide note was found; probe is underway. PTI



CLOSER LOOK

- » The girl was brought to the police station with her mother; three suspects were detained for questioning
- » A woman police officer was associated with the inquiry due to the sensitive nature of the case: Delhi Police
- » The girl was subsequently taken to AIIMS for medical examination with her mother and a woman constable

dence during the daytime on March 12 and March 13.

She alleged that the boys removed her undergarments and attempted to sexually assault her one by one, the officer said.

Based on her statement, a case was registered under sections 70 (rape) and 351 (criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita along with Section 6 (aggravated

penetrative sexual assault) of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, he added.

Police said all three minors were apprehended within hours of registration of the FIR. They are residents of Okhla area and come from economically weaker backgrounds. The accused juveniles have no previous criminal involvement, police said.

News at a Glance

WANTED CRIMINAL LINKED TO DELHI GANG NABBED FOR ARMED ASSAULT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested a 29-year-old alleged member of the Sheikh Firoz alias Saiful alias Dhinra gang operating in northwest Delhi's Jahangir Puri. The accused, Javed alias Kallu Dada, was wanted in an armed assault case. Previously convicted in a 2015 robbery-murder case, he had been evading arrest. He was held on March 10. Investigation continues.

MEDICAL & HEALTHCARE EXCELLENCE AWARDS HONOUR LEADING DOCTORS

NEW DELHI: The third edition of the Medical & Healthcare Excellence Awards was held in New Delhi, recognising leading medical professionals contributing to accessible and preventive healthcare in India. Organised by the Sitaram Jaipuria Foundation, the awards honoured excellence in medicine and healthcare. The top prize of Rs 50 lakh was awarded to Vinod K. Paul, Member (Health) at NITI Aayog and former head of paediatrics at AIIMS. Other awardees included Sahajal Dhoooria of PGIMER Chandigarh; rural healthcare pioneers Himmatrao Saluba Bawaskar and Sadanand Dagadu Raut; mental health expert Thara Rangaswamy of the Schizophrenia Research Foundation.

GZB: Bank manager shot dead by security guard after leave dispute

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GHAZIABAD: A bank manager was allegedly shot dead by a security guard inside a branch of Punjab & Sind Bank in the Loni Border area of Ghaziabad on Monday afternoon following a dispute over leave, officials said.

The incident occurred at the bank's Balram Nagar branch around 1.45 pm. The deceased has been identified as Abhishek Sharma, who had been serving as the branch manager for nearly a year. The accused security guard, Ravindra Hooda, a resident of Baghpat district, had joined the branch about three months ago.

According to police officials, Hooda had reportedly been seeking leave for the past few days, which had led to frequent disagreements with the manager. On Monday afternoon, another heated argument broke out between the two inside the bank over the



“Hooda had been seeking leave for the past few days, which had led to frequent disagreements with the manager”

same issue.

During the altercation, Hooda allegedly lost his temper, picked up his service double-barrel 12-bore gun and fired at Sharma, hitting him in the chest. The gunshot caused panic inside the bank, with customers and staff rushing

out in fear. After the shooting, the guard fled the spot while brandishing the weapon and escaped on a motorcycle parked outside the bank.

Bank employees and local residents rushed the injured manager to a nearby hospital without waiting for an ambulance. Due to the severity of his injuries, doctors later referred him to Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital in Delhi, where he died during treatment.

DCP (Rural) Surendranath Tiwari said the incident appeared to have stemmed from a dispute over leave between the manager and the guard. The accused fled the scene after firing the shot.

CCTV footage from the bank has been seized and is being examined as part of the investigation. Four teams have been formed to trace and arrest the accused guard, who remains absconding. Further investigation is underway, police said.

Truck driver killed after crashing into divider while fleeing accident site

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 32-year-old truck driver was killed after his vehicle crashed into a road divider and overturned in the Okhla Industrial Area in southeast Delhi while he was allegedly trying to flee after hitting a motorcycle at another location, police said on Monday.

The incident took place around 1 am on Monday near the SIS Proseur building in the Okhla Industrial Area.

Acting on a PCR call about the accident, a team reached the spot and found that a truck had overturned after ramming into a road divider near the Okhla underpass, a senior police officer said.

A man was found lying unconscious near the vehi-

cle, who was rushed to the AIIMS trauma centre, where doctors declared him dead, the officer said.

The deceased was later identified as Lokendra, a resident of Kasganj in Uttar Pradesh. Shortly before the fatal crash, the truck had hit a motorcycle near a petrol pump in Sarita Vihar, the officer said.

“Two persons – the bike rider and the person sitting behind – sustained injuries in the collision and were rushed to a nearby hospital, where their condition is stated to be stable,” he added.

After the collision, the truck driver allegedly fled the spot and crashed into the divider near the Okhla underpass after losing control of the truck.

Man booked for unauthorised LPG refilling

NEW DELHI: A 46-year-old man has been booked by Delhi Police for allegedly running an illegal LPG refilling and black-marketing operation from a shop in East Delhi's Shakarpur area, officials said.

The accused, identified as Yogesh Gupta (46), a resident of Shakarpur, was caught during a police raid conducted after a tip-off from an anonymous source about unauthorised LPG refilling activities in the locality. Police received information on March 15 about illegal LPG refilling in Shakarpur and conducted a raid at a shop. The accused, Yogesh Gupta, allegedly admitted to refilling LPG from larger cylinders into smaller ones without authorisation. The activity was being carried out without safety measures. Police recovered LPG cylinders, a refilling machine, a “totapilas” gas transferring tool and a weighing machine. An FIR has been registered. MPOST

ASI arrested while taking Rs 20,000 bribe to provide relief in dowry harassment case

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: An assistant sub-inspector posted at Geeta Colony Police Station in Delhi's Shahdara district was caught red-handed while allegedly accepting a bribe of Rs 20,000 from a complainant, officials said. The arrest was made by the Vigilance Unit of Delhi Police as part of an anti-corruption drive launched by Police Commissioner Satish Golchha.

The accused, identified as ASI Rohitash Kumar, was apprehended by the Vigilance Unit at Barakhamba Road

Police: ‘Kumar had been harassing and threatening him with strict legal action against him and other family members’

while accepting the tainted bribe amount from the complainant during a trap operation conducted at a pre-fixed time. According to police, Kumar was the investigating officer in a case registered at Geeta Colony Police Station. The complainant, a resident of Shahdara, had approached the Vigilance Unit alleging that his wife had filed a case against

him related to harassment for demand of dowry.

He alleged that Kumar had been harassing and threatening him with strict legal action against him and other family members named in the FIR. The officer allegedly demanded a bribe of Rs 40,000 to provide relief in the case and to avoid further harassment.

Following negotiations, the

amount was reportedly reduced to Rs 20,000, after which the complainant approached the Vigilance Unit and lodged a formal complaint.

Acting on the complaint, the Vigilance Unit laid a trap and caught the accused officer while he was accepting the bribe. The tainted money was recovered during the operation.

A case has been registered at Police Station Vigilance under Section 7 of the Prevention of Corruption Act. Delhi Police urged citizens to report bribery through the Vigilance Helpline 1064.

All GRAP restrictions lifted after Delhi air quality index improves

NEW DELHI: All restrictions imposed in Delhi-NCR under the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) have been revoked after a significant improvement in air quality, officials said on Monday.

The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) said that owing to favourable meteorological conditions, the air quality index (AQI) of Delhi was recorded at 119 on Monday.

“Further, the forecast by IMD and IITM indicates that AQI is likely to remain in the moderate category in the coming days,” an official said.

GRAP-1 restrictions had been in force under an order issued on October 14, 2025.

The revocation of the restrictions means that curbs such as a ban on the use of coal and firewood as fuel in tandoors in hotels, restaurants and open eateries, and the use of diesel generators only in emergency or essential situations will no longer be in place. There are four stages in GRAP, each linked to the AQI at the time.

The first stage, GRAP-1, kicks in when the AQI is

between 201 and 300; the second stage, GRAP-2, is invoked when the AQI is between 301 and 400; GRAP-3 kicks in between 401 and 500; and GRAP-4 is invoked when the AQI is more than 450.

This year, GRAP-4 restrictions were implemented on January 17. Since then, as air quality improved, lower stages of GRAP kicked in.

GRAP-4 was revoked on January 20. Two days later, restrictions under GRAP-3 were lifted, and GRAP-2 measures were removed on February 18. PTI

between 201 and 300; the second stage, GRAP-2, is invoked when the AQI is between 301 and 400; GRAP-3 kicks in between 401 and 500; and GRAP-4 is invoked when the AQI is more than 450.

This year, GRAP-4 restrictions were implemented on January 17. Since then, as air quality improved, lower stages of GRAP kicked in.

GRAP-4 was revoked on January 20. Two days later, restrictions under GRAP-3 were lifted, and GRAP-2 measures were removed on February 18. PTI

LPG crisis hits JNU canteens

NEW DELHI: Roti and poori have been removed from the mess menu for certain days at the Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), after gas supplies to the campus were cut by 20 per cent, prompting student organisations to request the administration to step in to ensure a smooth running of mess and dhabas.

Following the supply cut, the revised mess menu at the Lohit hostel specifies that roti will not be served at lunch on Tuesday and Saturday, with alternatives such as “only rice” or khichdi being provided instead.

According to two separate letters sent from the Indraprastha Gas Limited to the mess heads of the Sabarmati and Lohit hostels, “... supplies to all industrial and commercial customers are being restricted to 80 per cent of their average consumption for last six months with effect from 6 am on March 11, 2026”.

The food menus at several JNU canteens have also been affected by the shortage, according to student groups.

A statement issued by the Disha Students' Organisation (DSO) said some food items have already been removed from canteen menus due to the “impending crisis”. It cited examples, such as samosas no longer being served at the School of International Studies (SIS) canteen and tea being unavailable at the TEFLAS canteen.

JNUSU will march to the dean of students' office on Tuesday, demanding steps to ensure uninterrupted mess and dhaba services and prevent any increase in food prices. PTI

IYC protests against India-US trade deal; at least 90 detained

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Indian Youth Congress on Monday held a ‘Sansad Gherao’ at Jantar Mantar here to oppose the India-US trade deal, alleging that the agreement could adversely affect farmers, workers, and small businesses.

At least 90 protesters were detained as they attempted to march towards Parliament, a senior police officer said, adding that they would be released later.

In a video circulated on social media, a group of Youth Congress members claimed that after they were detained, a bus carrying them ran out of CNG midway.

“The police detained us and put us in a bus. But while we were being taken away, the bus ran out of CNG, and the police



had to leave us midway near the Patel Nagar metro station. This shows how severe the shortage of gas is in the country,” one of the members can be heard saying in the video posted on the X account of the Indian Youth Congress (IYC).

Led by IYC national president Uday Bhanu Chib, hundreds of Youth Congress workers from several states gathered at the protest site, raising slogans against the Cen-

tre and demanding that the government scrap the trade arrangement.

Addressing the gathering, Chib alleged that the trade arrangement could have serious implications for farmers and small businesses, and demanded that the government reconsider the agreement.

“The government must clarify whether this deal was signed keeping in mind the interests of farmers and young people of the country. We demand that the Centre scrap the agreement if it harms India's agricultural sector and domestic industries,” Chib said.

He also said that the Youth Congress would continue its agitation on the issue. “Our struggle will continue until the concerns of farmers and youth are addressed,” he added.

Student groups host Iftar gatherings to foster dialogue and unity at Jamia

Programmes encourage conversations on identity, social responsibility...

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A series of campus Iftar gatherings organised by the Students Islamic Organisation of India (SIO) at Jamia Millia Islamia brought together hundreds of students for discussions, reflection and community interaction during the holy month of Ramadan.

The programmes, held across different locations on the campus, provided a platform for students from various departments to engage in conversations on faith, values and the role of youth in society. The gatherings aimed to encourage meaningful dialogue and strengthen bonds among students while observing the spirit of Ramadan.



Several prominent speakers addressed the students during the interactions. Among them were Mohiuddin Ghazi and Shabbir Alam Khan, secretaries of Jamaat-e-Islami Hind, along with its assistant secretary Shadab Moosa. They spoke about the spiritual significance of Ramadan and the importance of ethical values and community engagement

among young people.

Academic perspectives were also shared by Khalid Mubashshir from the university's Department of Urdu, who interacted with students on themes of culture, literature and intellectual development.

Student leaders also participated in the programme, including Talha Mannan, National Secretary of SIO,

and Haris Neyazi, President of SIO Delhi. They highlighted the need for youth participation in constructive social initiatives and emphasised the importance of dialogue, learning and unity within educational spaces.

Participants said the gatherings created an environment where students could reflect on the values of patience, compassion and gratitude that Ramadan promotes. The events concluded with a collective Iftar where students broke their fast together, fostering solidarity and spiritual connection. Organisers said such initiatives promote campus bonding and encourage discussions on faith, identity and social responsibility.

PINK TICKET SCHEME FOR WOMEN TO CONTINUE FOR THREE MONTHS

Transgender residents can avail free travel on DTC, cluster buses

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a significant move aimed at expanding social inclusion in public transport, the Rekha Gupta government on Monday approved free bus travel for transgender persons across the national capital. The decision, taken under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, will allow eligible transgender residents of Delhi to travel free of cost on buses operated by Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and cluster buses run by the Transport Department.

The facility will be implemented on the same model currently used for women passengers, who avail free travel through the pink ticket scheme in Delhi buses.

Officials said the initiative is aimed at ensuring greater accessibility and mobility for the transgender community, allowing them to travel safely and without financial constraints. The government described the move as part of its broader effort to promote social justice and equitable access to public services.



‘Our govt remains committed to building a more inclusive Delhi’ FILE

Announcing the decision, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government is committed to ensuring dignity and inclusion for every section of society. “Our government remains committed to building a more inclusive, equitable and compassionate Delhi, where every citizen is able to access opportunities and public services with dignity,” she said.

The chief minister also addressed concerns among women passengers regarding changes to the existing free travel system. She clarified that the pink ticket scheme will continue for the next three months while the government gradually transitions to the new pink smart card system.

HIGHLIGHTS

» The facility will be implemented on the same model currently used for women passengers, who avail free travel through the pink ticket scheme

» Initiative is aimed at ensuring greater accessibility and mobility for the transgender community, allowing them to travel safely and without financial constraints: Officials

Under the Delhi government’s existing scheme, women can travel free on DTC and cluster buses using pink tickets. The administration is now in the process of replacing the ticket system with pink smart cards for eligible women residents of the city.

The decision to extend free bus travel to transgender persons is expected to further strengthen inclusive urban mobility in Delhi.

Gupta approves major road projos to ease traffic in Delhi

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to decongest Delhi’s busy roads, the Delhi government has approved two key infrastructure projects that promise signal-free travel between East and South Delhi and smoother traffic flow on one of the capital’s most congested stretches. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday cleared the long-pending Barapullah Phase-III elevated corridor and a six-lane elevated road on MB Road, while also ordering a probe into delays during the previous government’s tenure.

The decisions were taken in a Cabinet meeting chaired by the Chief Minister at the Delhi Secretariat.

The Barapullah Phase-III project, with a revised cost of Rs.1,635.03 crore, will extend the existing elevated corridor over the Barapullah drain, connecting Sarai Kale Khan to Mayur Vihar. Once completed, commuters will get direct signal-free connectivity from Mayur Vihar in East Delhi to AIIMS in South Delhi.



“The matter has been referred to the ACB to investigate why the project was delayed”

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the project would bring major relief to daily commuters. “The project will significantly reduce travel time for lakhs of people travelling between East and South Delhi,” she said.

She added that the government has set a deadline of June 30, 2026 to complete the project and has referred the earlier delays to the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB). “The matter has

been referred to the ACB to investigate why the project was delayed and who was responsible,” the Chief Minister said.

The Cabinet also approved a six-lane elevated corridor with underpasses on MB Road from Saket G-Block to Pul Prahladpur, estimated to cost Rs.1,471.14 crore. The project will be executed by the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) in two phases.

The first phase will include a double-decker structure between Saket G-Block and Sangam Vihar with a six-lane elevated flyover and multiple underpasses, while the second phase will see a 2.48-km elevated flyover built from Maa Anandmayee Marg to Pul Prahladpur.

Calling MB Road one of South Delhi’s most congested routes, Gupta said the project would ease traffic in Saket, Ambedkar Nagar, Khanpur, Sangam Vihar and Pul Prahladpur. “These projects are important steps toward building a ‘Viksit Delhi’ and strengthening the vision of a ‘Viksit Bharat,’” she said.

Lodhi Colony: Foundation stone laid for ₹9.45 cr power network upgrade

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma and MP Bansuri Swaraj on Sunday laid the foundation stone for the upgradation of the electric distribution network in Lodhi Colony, an initiative aimed at strengthening and modernising the area’s power infrastructure.

The project, undertaken by the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), seeks to improve voltage stability, reduce outages and ensure reliable electricity supply to residents of the Lodhi Colony Government Flats. The foundation stone ceremony was held at Central Park Corner, Main Market,



“Outdated system has struggled to meet the growing demand, often leading to voltage fluctuations and frequent power interruptions”

Lodhi Colony Road, in the presence of NDMC members Anil Valmiki and Sarita Tomar, senior officials and local residents.

According to officials, the existing electrical infrastructure in the colony was designed in the 1960s when the sanctioned load for each government flat was only 1 kilowatt. Over the years,

the power requirement has increased significantly to around 5–10 kilowatts per household. The outdated system has struggled to meet the growing demand, often leading to voltage fluctuations and frequent power interruptions, particularly during the summer months. To address these issues, NDMC has approved a project worth ₹9.45 crore

to upgrade the distribution network. The plan includes the installation of 40 SCADA-compatible smart feeder pillars for improved monitoring and control of the power supply system.

The project also involves laying 7.5 km of low-tension 1.1 KV 400 sq. mm cables and over 20 km of LT 1.1 KV 25 sq. mm cables across the colony. In addition, a 0.5 km stretch of 11 KV cable will be laid from the 33 KV Electric Sub-Station at Aliganj (Jor Bagh) to the 11 KV ESS at Block 5, Lodhi Colony.

Officials said the initiative is expected to enhance the efficiency and reliability of the power distribution system while supporting the growing electricity needs of residents.

CM Rekha Gupta attends ‘Phool Walon Ki Sair’ ceremony at Delhi Secretariat

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Secretariat witnessed a vibrant cultural moment on Monday as the historic festival Phool Walon Ki Sair was celebrated with a ceremonial event attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and several dignitaries. The occasion was marked by the sound of traditional shehnai music and the presentation of a floral fan by members of Anjuman Sair-e-Gul Faroshan, keeping alive a centuries-old tradition associated with the festival.

As part of the ceremony, representatives of the organisation extended a traditional welcome to the Chief Minister and honoured her with the custom-



ary floral fan, a symbolic gesture linked to the heritage of the festival. The melodious shehnai performance added a ceremonial ambience to the event, reflecting the spirit of Delhi’s composite culture and communal harmony.

Delhi Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra and other dignitaries were also present during

the ceremony.

Addressing the gathering, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta highlighted the deeper cultural significance of the festival. She said, “Phool Walon Ki Sair is far more than just a festival. It represents a remarkable example of Delhi’s shared cultural heritage and the spirit of harmony that defines the city.”

She further added that the tradition reminds people that “unity and brotherhood have always remained central to India’s diverse cultural fabric.”

The Chief Minister also emphasised the Delhi government’s commitment to preserving the capital’s historic traditions. According to her, such cultural celebrations play

an important role in connecting younger generations with their roots and strengthening mutual respect within society.

Speaking on the occasion, Kapil Mishra said the festival holds a special place in Delhi’s cultural history. He remarked, “Phool Walon Ki Sair is a historic tradition that conveys a message of harmony, unity and brotherhood while giving the younger generation an opportunity to experience Delhi’s rich cultural heritage.”

The festival Phool Walon Ki Sair 2026 is being organised in the city from March 15 to March 21 and includes a series of cultural, religious and social programmes celebrating Delhi’s diverse traditions.

Delhi Assembly Budget Session scheduled from March 23 to 25

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will hold the upcoming Budget Session of the Legislative Assembly from March 23 to March 25, setting the stage for the presentation of the government’s financial roadmap for the coming year.

The decision was taken during a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at the Delhi Secretariat on Monday. The brief three-day session will include the tabling of the Economic Survey and the presentation of the Delhi government’s annual budget.

According to the Cabinet’s decision, the Economic Survey report will be tabled in the Assembly on March 23. The document will provide a detailed assessment of Delhi’s economic performance over the past year, including key indicators related to growth,



revenue, public spending and sectoral developments.

The Delhi government will present its budget for the upcoming financial year on March 24. The budget is expected to outline the government’s priorities across sectors such as infrastructure, education, healthcare, transport and urban development.

Officials said the session will also provide legislators an opportunity to discuss the government’s policy direction and financial allocations for various departments. The Budget Session is considered one of the most important legislative

exercises of the year as it determines how public funds will be allocated for development projects and welfare schemes in the national capital. The Economic Survey, traditionally presented a day before the budget, acts as a precursor to the budget document and offers insights into the economic trends and fiscal position of the government.

With preparations underway, the upcoming session is expected to focus on key governance priorities and development plans aimed at improving infrastructure, public services and overall quality of life for Delhi residents.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Legislative Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta has written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, expressing concern over the recent attempt by certain opposition parties to move a resolution seeking the Speaker’s removal in the Lok Sabha.

In his letter, Gupta said the move undermines long-standing parliamentary traditions and the dignity of the Chair. He emphasised that the Speaker’s office holds exceptional importance in India’s parliamentary democracy and must remain above partisan politics.

“It is deeply saddening that certain opposition parties, driven by narrow political considerations, chose to bring a motion against the incumbent Speaker—an office that stands above partisan politics and is entrusted with safeguarding



He emphasised that the Speaker’s office holds exceptional importance in India’s parliamentary democracy and must remain above partisan politics

the rules, traditions and dignity of Parliament,” Gupta said. The motion seeking the removal of the Lok Sabha

Speaker was defeated by a voice vote in the House, reaffirming the confidence of Members in the authority and impartial functioning of the Chair.

“The neutrality of the Chair is central to India’s parliamentary democracy,” Gupta said, stressing that the credibility of parliamentary institutions depends on preserving the dignity, neutrality and authority associated with the office.

Gupta also appreciated Members of Parliament who opposed the motion, describing their stand as a reaffirmation of the House’s commitment to protecting parliamentary traditions.

He further said that under the stewardship of Om Birla, the Lok Sabha has continued to function with balance and dignity, enabling meaningful democratic debate while maintaining discipline and decorum.

MCD clears 60 tonnes of garbage from tracks



ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Monday intensified its sanitation and enforcement efforts across the city, removing nearly 60 metric tonnes of waste from railway tracks in Rohini Zone and attaching a guest house in Karol Bagh Zone over unpaid property tax dues.

As part of an ongoing sanitation campaign, civic officials conducted an intensive cleanliness drive along railway tracks stretching from Kirari Phatak to Nangloi. The drive was carried out under the supervision of Rohini Zone Deputy Commissioner Rishita Gupta, along with sanitation staff and other officials.

During the operation, around 60 metric tonnes of waste were cleared from the tracks. Officials said certain low-lying stretches faced water logging, requiring manual cleaning

TAKEAWAYS

» Civic officials conducted an intensive cleanliness drive along rly tracks stretching from Kirari Phatak to Nangloi

» Drive was carried out under supervision of Rohini Zone Dy Commissioner Rishita Gupta

» During the op, around 60 metric tonnes of waste were cleared from the tracks. Officials said certain low-lying stretches faced water logging, requiring manual cleaning

low-lying area. Officials were instructed to take preventive measures and ensure proper maintenance of the facility. Several residential lanes were also found with clogged drains, prompting immediate directions for their clearance.

Meanwhile, in a separate enforcement action, MCD attached a three-storey guest house in the Karol Bagh Zone for failing to clear property tax dues amounting to about ₹32 lakh for several years. The property, located in the Paharganj ward, was attached after repeated notices to the owner went unanswered.

The civic body urged residents to avoid littering, segregate waste at source and ensure timely payment of property taxes to support civic services.

‘Delhi govt plans bus service to Vaishno Devi, Khatu Shyam...’

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is planning to launch inter-state bus services to major religious destinations including Katra (Vaishno Devi), Khatu Shyam in Rajasthan and Ayodhya, Transport Minister Pankaj Singh said on Monday.

The Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) will also deploy 50 AC buses on 17 inter-state routes to strengthen regional connectivity. Officials said services will operate as per benchmark rates set by the Association of State Road Transport Undertakings. New routes such as Delhi–Rewari, Delhi–Karnal, Delhi–Rohtak, Delhi–Alwar and Delhi–Jewar are also planned. The government is exploring bus connectivity with Bihar. PFI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at strengthening Delhi’s preparedness ahead of the monsoon season, Delhi’s Irrigation and Flood Control Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Monday laid the foundation stone for a new Flood Control Monitoring Centre at the L.M. Bund Office Complex in Shastri Nagar. Senior officers and engineers of the Irrigation and Flood Control Department were present during the ceremony.

The project involves the construction of a dedicated building that will function as the central Flood Control Monitoring Centre for the department. According to



officials, the project has been approved at an estimated cost of Rs.355.72 lakh and is scheduled to be completed by June 15, 2026, ahead of the peak monsoon period.

Officials said the ground floor of the proposed building will house the main Flood Control

Room, which will be used to monitor river water levels, review field reports and coordinate emergency responses during the flood season. The first floor will include a conference and coordination hall with seating capacity for around 50 people, enabling officials,

engineers and field teams to conduct review meetings and operational briefings during critical situations.

Speaking after laying the foundation stone, Verma said the Delhi government is focused on strengthening institutional infrastructure to ensure quicker and more effective responses during emergencies.

“Every monsoon, our engineers and field teams work day and night to monitor river levels, drainage systems and vulnerable locations across Delhi. Facilities like this monitoring centre will ensure that coordination becomes smoother and decisions can be taken quickly when the situation demands,” he said.

Highlighting the importance of preparedness, the minister added, “Our aim is simple, better monitoring, better coordination and faster response. This centre will act as a nerve centre during the monsoon season where officers and engineers can review the situation in real time and guide field operations accordingly.”

Officials said that once completed, the monitoring centre will strengthen the department’s capacity to manage flood-related situations by providing a dedicated space for monitoring, planning and coordination. The initiative is part of the government’s broader efforts to improve flood control and drainage systems across the capital.

IN BELGIUM'S BRUSSELS

EAM Jaishankar discusses Iran conflict with EU counterparts

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met with his counterparts from the 27 member states of the European Union (EU) in Brussels focusing on global flashpoints in Ukraine and West Asia as well as ways to deepen India's relations with Europe. Jaishankar is on a two-day visit to the Belgian capital at the invitation of EU Foreign and Security Policy Chief Kaja Kallas to attend a meeting of the Foreign Affairs Council of the bloc.

It is the first high-level visit from India to Brussels headquartered EU after the two sides firmed up a landmark



EAM S Jaishankar during a meeting with President of the European Commission Ursula von der Leyen, in Brussels, Belgium

Free Trade Agreement (FTA) in January.

The external affairs minister held separate meetings with European Commission presi-

dent Ursula von der Leyen and his counterparts from Germany, Greece and Belgium.

"A new chapter in India-EU ties has opened up in 2026," Jais-

hankar said in an apparent reference to the outcomes reached by the two sides in their summit meeting in January in New Delhi.

"The Foreign Ministers coordinate translating the various agreements into outcomes. Our conversation today therefore covered trade, investment, technology, mobility and defence in particular," he said on social media.

"The stronger convergence between India and EU in a multipolar world is also expressed in closer consultations. Discussed the West Asia conflict, the Ukraine situation and the Indo-Pacific in today's gathering," he said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

India-US trade agreement awaits clarity...

Continued from Page 1 Following the ruling, the US administration imposed a temporary tariff of 10 per cent on all countries for 150 days starting February 24.

Because of these developments, a meeting between the chief negotiators of the two countries that had been scheduled last month to finalise the legal text of the agreement has been postponed. The pact had earlier been expected to be signed in March.

"The deal was to be signed in March. When we said this, that time, the Supreme Court judgment on IEEPA tariffs had not come," the official said. The ruling related to tariffs imposed under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act.

"Now, with the Supreme Court judgment on IEEPA tariffs, the tariffs per se don't exist," the official added. Instead, tariffs are currently being applied under Article 122 provisions

related to balance of payments crises, which allow duties to be imposed for five months. These tariffs are currently around 10 per cent.

Officials said the final signing of the agreement will depend on how the United States restructures its broader tariff framework. "The deal that we finalise and sign has to be against the tariff structure or the comparative advantage that India gets in the US market," the official said.

According to the official, Washington is in the process of building a new global tariff architecture. "Once they are on that pathway and are able to create that, I think at that juncture it would be right to sign the deal," the official said.

Negotiators from both countries have already completed the main elements of the pact and are now working through remaining details. "The pact has already been finalised and decided upon, and both teams are negotiating to iron out the

finer details," the official said, adding that the signing will take place once the broader tariff system is clear.

India's earlier negotiated tariff rate of 18 per cent had placed it at a relative advantage compared with competitors such as China, Vietnam and Thailand. Officials noted that any changes to this rate will depend on how the new US tariff structure treats other countries. "If the global architecture is exactly the way the IEEPA tariffs were there, then it may also remain so. If it is different, then it may also change," another official said. If competing economies face tariffs of 19 to 22 per cent, India's rate may remain at 18 per cent, but it could be adjusted if other countries receive lower rates.

Officials said there is no disagreement between the two sides. "There is nothing that there is a standoff. There is nothing that the deal is not there," the official said.

The agreement focuses on

providing comparative and preferential market access to both countries. Meanwhile, the United States has launched two investigations under Section 301 of its trade law. On March 12, the US Trade Representative initiated a probe covering 60 economies, including India and China, to examine policies related to the import of goods produced using forced labour. A day earlier, another Section 301 investigation targeted the industrial policies of 16 economies, again including India and China.

Officials in New Delhi said the government is reviewing the legal implications of these investigations.

"These investigations take time. My sense is whenever a trade deal is finalised and signed in the future, this will take care of these investigations," the official said. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal said India continues to work with Washington toward a mutually beneficial agreement.

From Page 1

Iran

Firefighters contained the blaze, and there were no injuries reported, but the airport suspended all flights before resuming them a few hours later.

Later, a person was killed in the capital of the United Arab Emirates when an Iranian missile hit a vehicle, the Abu Dhabi media office said. Fire also broke out at an oil facility in Fujairah, one of the UAE's seven emirates, following a drone attack.

Saudi Arabia, meanwhile, said it intercepted a wave of 35 Iranian drones sent to its eastern region, home to major oil installations.

Iran has fired hundreds of missiles and drones toward countries in the region hosting US military assets since the war began. Israel's military said early Monday that Iran launched missiles toward Israel as well.

The conflict is battering the world economy, driving up energy and fertiliser prices; threatening food shortages in poor countries; destabilising fragile states; and complicating efforts by central banks to drive down prices for consumers. Much of the difficulty stems from the virtual shutdown of the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump said Sunday he wants to police the strait to make it safe for shipping, with his party increasingly concerned that rising prices for American consumers will hurt the Republicans in elections this fall.

He did not identify the countries he said he asked to help with those efforts, but he said he won't forget the countries that declined. He has previously appealed to China, France, Japan, South Korea and Britain.

"Whether we get support or not, but I can say this, and I said to them: We will remember," Trump said.

He also suggested he might delay a planned trip to China, a key trade partner of Iran, as he seeks to pressure Beijing into helping restore the flow of shipping through the strait.

Ahead of a meeting in Brussels, the European Union's foreign policy chief, Kaja Kallas, said the bloc's foreign ministers would discuss possibly extending a naval mission that protects ships in the Red Sea to the Strait of Hormuz, without giving any details. Europeans have been critical of the US and Israel for failing to provide clarity on their objectives in the war, and German Foreign Minister Johann Wadepuhl on Sunday questioned EU involvement, saying security for the strait can only come "if there is a negotiated solution."

Japan and Australia both said Monday that they had not been asked to help protect the strait and had no current plans to do so.

Massive explosions were heard in Beirut as Israel launched new attacks on the Lebanese capital before dawn, saying it was striking infrastructure related to the Iran-linked Hezbollah militia group.

The Israeli army has issued evacuation orders for many neighbourhoods in Beirut as well as southern Lebanon. To date, more than 800,000 people have been displaced by Israel's campaign in Lebanon.

In southern Lebanon, seven people were killed in Israeli airstrikes, according to authorities and news reports. Lebanon's state-run National News Agency said two of them were paramedics responding to an earlier strike. At

least 850 people have been killed by Israeli strikes so far.

More than 1,300 people have been killed in Iran so far, according to the Iranian Red Crescent. Israel has carried out some 7,600 strikes on Iran so far, knocking out 85 per cent of its air defences, military spokesman Lt. Col. Nadav Shoshani said. It has also destroyed 70 per cent of Iran's missile launchers, but Shoshani said Israel still has thousands of targets to hit and would continue attacks "for as long as needed."

In Israel, 12 people have been killed by Iranian missile fire. At least 13 US military members have been killed.

Rajya Sabha

The Opposition Mahagathabandhan struggled to mount an effective challenge. Three Congress MLAs and one Rashtriya Janata Dal legislator were absent during voting. Under the formula used for the Rajya Sabha polls in Bihar, each candidate would have needed at least 41 votes to secure victory if all 243 members of the Assembly had cast their ballots.

RJD candidate Amarendra Dhari Singh lost despite claims by opposition leader Tejashwi Yadav that he had support from five legislators of the All India Majlis-e-Mtehadul Muslimeen and one from the Bahujan Samaj Party. The AIMIM, which has five MLAs in the Assembly, and the BSP legislator said they voted in favour of Singh.

In Odisha, voting took place for four Rajya Sabha seats with five candidates in the race. The BJP won three seats while the opposition BJD secured one. The outcome was influenced by cross voting during the ballot. Reports indicated that at least five MLAs, including three from the Congress and two from the BJD, supported the BJP-backed independent candidate Dilip Ray.

Those elected from Odisha include BJP state president Manmohan Samal and sitting Rajya Sabha member Sujeet Kumar, along with BJD nominee Santrupt Misra and independent candidate Dilip Ray. The fifth candidate, eminent urologist Dr Datteswar Hota, had the backing of the Congress and the CPI M but did not secure enough support.

Odisha Assembly secretary and Returning Officer Satyabrata Rout later handed over certificates to the newly elected members. Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi congratulated the winners, writing in a post on X that he extended "heartfelt congratulations and best wishes" to Samal, Sujeet Kumar and Ray. In Haryana, voting was conducted for two Rajya Sabha seats, but counting of ballots was suspended after both the BJP and the Congress filed complaints alleging breaches of vote secrecy. Voting concluded at 4 pm and counting was scheduled to begin an hour later.

The contest in Haryana has drawn attention because of earlier instances of cross-voting in the state. BJP candidate Sanjay Bhatia, Congress nominee Karamvir Singh Boudh and independent candidate Satish Nandal are among those in the fray.

Congress MLAs who had been moved to Himachal Pradesh before polling returned to cast their votes. Commenting on the move, Haryana minister Anil Vij said the Congress leadership had relocated its legislators because it did not trust them. Vij himself arrived at the polling station in a wheelchair after fracturing both his legs in a recent fall.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge wrote to the Election Commission alleging attempts to inter-

fere with the election process and asked for a meeting with the poll body. In the letter, he said there was "a clear attempt to interfere with the integrity of the election" and urged the commission to address the issue immediately. The letter also stated that no disqualification of legitimate voters or votes cast should be allowed.

Meanwhile, several other candidates across states had already secured seats unopposed. In Maharashtra, all seven candidates were elected without contest, including six from the ruling Mahayuti alliance and opposition nominee Sharad Pawar.

In West Bengal, the ruling Trinamool Congress saw four of its candidates elected unopposed. They include Babul Supriyo, former state police chief Rajeev Kumar, Supreme Court advocate Menaka Guruswamy and actor Koel Mallick. The BJP's former state president Rahul Sinha was also elected without a contest.

Unopposed elections were also reported in Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Himachal Pradesh. In Telangana, Congress candidates Abhishek Singhvi and Vem Narendar Reddy secured seats. Tamil Nadu saw six candidates elected unopposed, including AIADMK member M Thambidurai, PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss, DMK nominees Tiruchi Siva and J Constantine Ravindran, Congress candidate M Christopher Tilak and DMKD treasurer L K Sudeesh.

In Himachal Pradesh, Congress candidate Anurag Sharma, a close associate of Chief Minister Sukhwindar Singh Sukhu, was also elected to the Upper House.

With the results from the latest round of polls, the BJP is set to hold the largest number of seats in the Rajya Sabha.

EC removes

The state administration was instructed to submit a compliance report confirming the joining of the newly appointed officers by 3 pm on March 16.

The IAS officer Dushyant Nari-ala has been asked to take charge as the new Chief Secretary of West Bengal. Nari-ala, a 1993-batch IAS officer, was serving as the Additional Chief Secretary of the North Bengal Development Department. He has earlier handled important departments, including Disaster Management and Civil Defence.

IAS officer Sanghamitra Ghosh, a 1997-batch officer, has been appointed as the Principal Secretary of the Home and Hill Affairs Department. She had been serving as Principal Secretary of the Women and Child Development and Social Welfare Department.

In a parallel move, the Commission ordered a major reshuffle in the state police administration. Peeyush Pandey has been removed from the post of Director General of Police and senior IPS officer Siddh Nath Gupta, a 1992-batch officer, has been appointed as the new DGP.

The Commission also replaced the Commissioner of Kolkata Police, Supratim Sarkar, and reinstated Ajay Nanda, a 1996-batch IPS officer, in his place.

Nanda has previously served as Commissioner of the Asansol-Durgapur Police Commissionerate and held several assignments in Kolkata Police. He has also played a key role in anti-Maoist operations and was the first Inspector General of the West Bengal Special Task Force (STF).

The poll body also replaced ADG (Law and Order) Vineet Goyal with Ajay Mukund Ranade, a 1995-batch IPS officer, who has been appointed as ADG and IGP

(Law and Order).

Natarajan Ramesh Babu, a 1991-batch IPS officer, has been appointed Director General of Correctional Services.

The Commission said the decision was taken after reviewing the administrative preparedness of the state ahead of the Assembly elections. It also directed that officers transferred out should not be posted in any election-related assignments until the completion of the polls.

The state Home department also issued a notification announcing fresh postings for the officers who were moved from their earlier positions. Peeyush Pandey has been appointed Director Security in the rank of Director General, while Supratim Sarkar has been assigned the charge of ADG, CID. Vineet Goyal has been posted as Director General of the Intelligence Branch of the state police.

Laxmi Narayan Meena, who was serving as ADG, CID, has been given the charge of ADG, Correctional Services. Manoj Verma, who was Director Security, has been posted as Additional Director, Security in the rank of ADG.

Immediately after the announcement of the elections, the Model Code of Conduct came into force across the state, giving the Commission powers to order transfers of bureaucrats, police officers and other officials during the election period.

Meanwhile, it emerged that the state secretariat Nabanna had issued a notification regarding the transfer of 30 WBCS (Executive) officers. Though the notification was made public on Monday, it stated that the order had been issued earlier on March 13.

According to the notification issued by the WBCS Cell of the Personnel and Administrative Reforms Department, the reshuffle includes appointments to the posts of Additional District Magistrates (ADMs) in several districts.

Among those transferred, Ananta Chandra Sarkar, who was serving in the Tourism Department, has been appointed ADM of North Dinajpur. Pushpak Roy, Assistant Commissioner of the Malda Division, has also been posted as ADM in the same district.

Bishnubrata Bhattacharya from the IT and Electronics Department has been appointed ADM of Murshidabad, while Sudipta Das, Joint Secretary of the Panchayats and Rural Development Department, has been given the responsibility of ADM of Nadia district.

Shubhalakshmi Basu, Joint Secretary in the Tribal Development Department, and Brijit Suchita Kujur, Joint Secretary in the Health and Family Welfare Department, have both been posted as ADM of North 24-Parganas.

Several officers, including Deepanjan De, Koyalee Das and Pushpen Chatterjee, have also been brought into different state government departments as Senior Deputy Secretaries or Joint Secretaries.

Sources in the state administration said that the process of administrative reorganisation had been underway even before the announcement of the elections, and the notification was part of that process.

India denies

Prior to the escalation, more than half of India's crude imports and a large share of its gas and LPG supplies came from Middle Eastern producers including Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said India does not have a "blanket arrangement" with Iran allowing Indian-flagged ships to

pass through the Strait of Hormuz and that each transit requires separate coordination.

"Every ship movement is an individual happening," Jaishankar said in an interview with the Financial Times from Brussels. He added that talks with Tehran had helped secure passage for some vessels. "I am at the moment engaged in talking to them and my talking has yielded some results. This is ongoing."

He also rejected suggestions that India had offered concessions in return for allowing its ships to pass. "It's not an exchange issue," Jaishankar said, noting that India and Iran maintain longstanding ties even as the current conflict remains "very unfortunate."

Two Indian-flagged LPG carriers, Shivalki and Nanda Devi, carrying a combined cargo of 92,712 metric tonnes of LPG crossed the Strait of Hormuz earlier this month. The volume is roughly equivalent to India's daily cooking gas requirement.

Maritime authorities say progress is being made in clearing other Indian vessels stranded near the strait. According to Rajesh Kumar Sinha, Special Secretary in the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, an Indian-flagged crude oil tanker, Jag Laadki, carrying about 80,800 tonnes of Murban crude from the UAE's Fujairah port is scheduled to reach India on Tuesday. The vessel sailed safely despite an attack on the Fujairah oil terminal while it was loading. All 22 Indian crew members on board are reported safe.

Sinha said Jag Laadki is the fourth among 28 Indian ships that had been stuck in the conflict-affected area over the past two weeks. As of now, 22 Indian-flagged vessels carrying 611 seafarers remain in the western Persian Gulf, while two ships are still on the western side of the Strait of Hormuz. Another tanker, Jag Prakash, which loaded gasoline at Sohar port in Oman, crossed the strait on Friday and is heading toward Tanga in Tanzania, where it is expected to arrive on March 21.

The Directorate General of Shipping has set up a control room to assist Indian seafarers and their families. Authorities said more than 3,000 phone calls and about 5,400 emails have been handled so far, while 286 Indian seafarers have been repatriated, including 33 in the past 48 hours.

Meanwhile, India has also been assisting its nationals stranded in Iran as the conflict spreads across the Gulf region. External Affairs Minister Jaishankar said more than 550 Indians have been evacuated from Iran through Armenia so far. "Thank the Government and the people of Armenia for facilitating the safe evacuation of over 550 Indian nationals from Iran so far. Appreciate their support in these challenging times," he said on social media.

Officials estimate that around 9,000 Indian nationals remain in Iran, including students, seafarers, businesspeople, professionals and pilgrims. Some have already been moved from Tehran to safer locations within the country.

The Indian Embassy in Tehran has issued an advisory urging citizens not to attempt to cross land borders without prior coordination. The mission warned that those leaving the country without embassy guidance could face logistical and immigration difficulties and that assistance may not be possible once individuals exit Iranian territory.

Alongside evacuation and shipping efforts, India has called for a reduction in tensions in the region. Jaiswal reiterated New Delhi's position during the briefing.

"We continue to call for de-

escalation, for exercise of restraint and for countries to adopt the path of dialogue and diplomacy so that there can be an early end to this conflict," he said, adding that the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all states must be respected.

SC quashes

had chosen not to pursue prosecution against Mahmudabad. "As a one-time magnanimity, we have closed the issue by not according sanction," Raju said, while also urging that the professor be cautioned against similar conduct in the future.

Taking note of the state's decision, the bench said the proceedings before the trial court would stand closed. The court expressed confidence that Mahmudabad, describing him as "a highly learned professor and a domain expert," would act with prudence in the future. The Chief Justice also observed that public writing requires caution in sensitive situations. "Sometimes, the writing in between the lines creates more problems. Sometimes, the situation is so sensitive that we all have to be careful," he said while addressing the professor's legal team.

The top court had earlier suggested that the state consider declining sanction as a gesture of magnanimity after noting that the Haryana government had been sitting on the question since August 2025, when a chargesheet was filed in the case.

Mahmudabad was arrested by Haryana Police on May 18, 2025, following two FIRs registered over his social media posts on Operation Sindoor, which authorities alleged endangered the sovereignty and integrity of the country. The complaints were filed by Haryana State Commission for Women chairperson Renu Bhatia and a village sarpanch, and the FIRs were lodged at Rai police station in Sonapat district.

He was booked under several provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including Sections 152, 353, 79 and 196(1). On May 21, 2025, the Supreme Court granted him interim bail but allowed the investigation to continue, directing a three-member Special Investigation Team to examine the allegations.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Cuttack

injuries while attempting to rescue patients from the smoke-filled unit. At least 13 people were injured in total, and officials said the condition of five among them remains critical.

Fire service personnel rushed to the hospital soon after the incident and brought the flames under control. Hospital staff, police, patient attendants and firefighters worked together to evacuate patients from the affected ICU and shift them to other departments within the hospital.

Majhi visited the hospital along with Health Minister Mukesh Mahaling and reviewed the situation. "I have directed the concerned officers for proper treatment of the injured patients and staff," he said.

The chief minister stated that 11 medical officials who took part in the rescue operation were injured while risking their lives and are currently undergoing treatment in a hospital ward.

He said the fire likely originated from a short circuit. The state government has ordered both a judicial inquiry and a fact-finding investigation into the incident.

A six-member fact-finding team headed by Development

Commissioner D K Singh has been asked to visit the hospital and submit a report to the chief secretary by Monday evening, according to a statement from the Chief Minister's Office. Majhi also directed the Director General of Fire Services to personally visit the hospital and examine fire safety compliance.

"If anyone is found guilty in the incident after the judicial probe, strong action will be taken," the chief minister said.

Majhi also announced an ex gratia payment of Rs 25 lakh to the families of each deceased patient.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi expressed grief over the loss of lives and announced financial assistance from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund. "The mishap at a hospital in Cuttack, Odisha, is deeply painful. Condolences to those who have lost their loved ones," the Prime Minister's Office said on X, adding that Rs 2 lakh would be given to the next of kin of each deceased and Rs 50,000 to the injured.

The prime minister also spoke with Majhi to review the situation. The chief minister said he briefed him on the rescue operation and medical care being provided to the injured.

President Droupadi Murmu, Vice President C P Radhakrishnan, Odisha Governor H B Kamthampati, Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and Leader of Opposition Naveen Patnaik also expressed grief over the incident and prayed for the recovery of those injured.

UAE orders

to detect online material that could misinform the public or affect national security amid the ongoing regional security situation linked to the Israel-US-Iran conflict.

The accused were identified in two stages. Ten individuals were first named and placed under investigation, followed by a second group of 25 people from various nationalities. Among the 35 accused, 19 are Indians.

According to prosecutors, investigators found that the suspects were involved in three categories of online activity. The first group circulated genuine video clips showing air defence systems intercepting projectiles or debris following incidents. Officials said these videos were accompanied by commentary and sound effects that suggested active attacks, potentially causing anxiety and exposing sensitive defence capabilities.

A second group was accused of creating or distributing fabricated visuals, including clips generated using artificial intelligence. These videos reportedly depicted explosions, missile strikes, or fires and sometimes reused footage from incidents outside the UAE while falsely claiming they occurred within the country.

Authorities also said some posts attempted to heighten emotional reactions by featuring children and suggesting security threats.

The third group was accused of sharing content that praised a state involved in the conflict and promoted its political and military leadership. Prosecutors said such posts circulated propaganda that could undermine national interests and support hostile narratives.

All suspects have been placed in custody while investigations continue. Under UAE law, spreading misleading information that threatens public security can lead to imprisonment of at least one year and a fine of no less than AED 100,000. Authorities had earlier warned residents against filming or sharing footage related to defence responses or incident sites.

AGENCIES

WARNS OF TRADE, JOBS AND ENERGY FALLOUT

Oppn attacks govt on West Asia crisis

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Opposition parties in the Rajya Sabha on Monday criticised the government over its handling of the West Asia crisis, warning of severe repercussions for India's trade, employment, energy security and rural economy.

Participating in a debate over the Appropriation Bill, CPI's Sandosh Kumar P said the conflict was not a distant political issue but one with "direct consequences" for India.

AAP's Sanjay Singh alleged the crisis was "self-imposed" due to strained ties with Iran. BJP's Sulata Deo flagged LPG shortages, and YSRCP's S Niranjan Reddy cautioned about looming fertiliser challenges, underscoring the vulnerability of India's agriculture sector.

Sandosh Kumar said the ongoing conflict in West Asia is not a distant political issue for India.

"It has direct consequences for our trade, employment, and energy security. Unfortunately,



Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh Narayan Singh conducts proceedings in the House, in New Delhi, Monday

PTI

despite the gravity of the situation, the Union government appears unprepared," he said.

Over India's economic dependence on the Gulf region, the CPI member said India's total trade with the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) is about USD 178 billion and exports to these countries are USD 56-57 billion annually. India's exports include agricultural products, food items, textiles, engineering goods, and pharmaceuticals.

Moreover, it employs millions of workers across rural and semi-urban India.

"If the conflict continues

and trade routes are disrupted, these exports will decline. This will directly affect farmers, small producers, and workers, leading to unemployment, particularly in the rural economy," he said.

At such times, the rural economy earlier had a cushion in MGNREGA, a programme that provided livelihood security. But this government has systematically weakened it with another VB-G RAM G (Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission Gramin) framework, which is still not even notified.

He asked what contin-

Highlights

- » AAP's Sanjay Singh alleged the crisis was "self-imposed" due to strained ties with Iran
- » - 'Unfortunately, despite the gravity of the situation, the Union government appears unprepared'

gency plans does the government have to deal with such a situation?

"How will it support returning workers and protect the families that depend on these incomes? Another concern is energy security. India imports more than 85 per cent of crude oil requirements. Much of it is linked to supplies from West Asia," he said.

Kumar said there is a need to understand the reality and address it.

AAP member Sanjay Singh said the Leader of House has said that the Opposition is not cooperating in this crisis. How-

ever, Singh asked who brought this crisis to India.

He called this a self-imposed crisis. The government knew that 60 per cent of the crude and 50 per cent gas meant for India passes through the Strait of Hormuz.

When over 60 per cent of the strait comes under control of Iran, then what was the need to have an adverse relationship with Iran, he alleged.

Singh alleged that this crisis, which the nation is facing today, is sponsored by the Prime Minister.

"Iran was our traditional friend, this was also mentioned by our Prime Minister, when he had earlier visited Iran," he said.

"However when Khamenei was killed, he remains silent. 160 school children are killed and we remained silent."

Not only this, one of the Iranian ships which was returning after participating in a military exercise hosted by India was torpedoed by the US. In this more than 100 of its crew members died and the Prime Minister remained silent.

TRASHES USCIRF REPORT

MEA: 'Motivated and biased characterisation of India'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Monday categorically rejected a report by the US Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF) that called for linking Washington's security assistance and bilateral trade to improvements in New Delhi's record in religious freedom.

In its report, the USCIRF criticised India for what it called increasing cases of alleged violations of religious freedom and recommended "targeted sanctions" on individuals and entities such as the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW), holding them responsible for the situation.

The USCIRF is an independent, bipartisan US federal government agency that monitors universal right to freedom of religion.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), trashing the report, said the USCIRF has persisted in presenting a "distorted and selective" picture of India,

Closer Look

- » The USCIRF is an independent, bipartisan US federal government agency that monitors universal right to freedom of religion
- » USCIRF criticised India for what it called increasing cases of alleged violations of religious freedom and recommended 'targeted sanctions'

relying on "questionable sources and ideological narratives" rather than objective facts.

The USCIRF said that future US security assistance and trade with India should be linked to improvements in religious freedom in the country. It also called for designating India as a "Country of Particular Concern" while citing cases of alleged worsening of religious freedom in the

country.

"We have taken note of the latest report of the US Commission on International Religious Freedom. We categorically reject its motivated and biased characterisation of India," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said.

"For several years now, USCIRF has persisted in presenting a distorted and selective picture of India, relying on questionable sources and ideological narratives rather than objective facts," he said.

Jaiswal said such "repeated misrepresentations" only undermine the credibility of the commission itself.

"Instead of persisting with selective criticism of India, USCIRF would do well to reflect on the disturbing incidents of vandalism and attacks on Hindu temples in the United States, selective targeting of India, and growing intolerance and intimidation of members of the Indian diaspora in the United States, which merit serious attention," he said.

LOK SABHA

MPs seek restoration of train fare concessions for senior citizens

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Several members in Lok Sabha on Monday urged the government to restore the 50 per cent concession in train fares given to senior citizens and journalists that was discontinued during the Covid pandemic.

Initiating the debate on the demands for grants for the Ministry of Railways, Congress leader Tariq Anwar said the decision to suspend the train fare concession had caused severe disappointment to the affected people, especially the elderly.

"I urge the railway minister

to clarify when the concessions given in the train tickets to the senior citizens will be restored," he said.

A similar demand was also made by Trinamool Congress member June Maliah, who urged the government to restore the concessions in train fares to senior citizens, journalists and cultural activists as early as possible.

"These concessions are gestures of respect for individuals who contribute to the social, cultural and democratic life of our country," Maliah said.

Before the COVID-19 lockdown in March 2020, the Indian Railways offered a 50 per cent

concession on train fares to senior citizens and government-accredited journalists.

A Parliamentary standing committee in 2023 had recommended the resumption of the fare concession offered to senior citizens by the railways before the coronavirus pandemic.

The concessions were granted in fares of all classes of Mail/Express/Rajdhani/Shatabdi/Duranto group of trains but were withdrawn on March 20, 2020.

Senior citizens in the category of males and transgender individuals were entitled to a 40 per cent concession and 50 per cent for female senior citizens.

DURING DISCUSSION ON THE APPROPRIATION BILL IN RAJYA SABHA

MPs bat for higher allocations for Tribal, Minority Affairs ministries and PM Kisan Nidhi Scheme

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Rajya Sabha members on Monday batted for enhanced Budget allocations for ministries such as Labour and Employment, Minority Affairs and Tribal Affairs.

Demands for allocation of funds to deal with the cyclones in Odisha and tax exemption on disability pensions were also made during the discussion on the Appropriation Bill.

RJD MP Prof Manoj Kumar Jha said it is a matter of concern that Budget allocations to the Ministry of Labour and Employment, the Ministry of

Takeaways

- » Demands for allocation of funds to deal with cyclones in Odisha and tax exemption on disability

pensions were also made

- » - 'Amount paid to farmers under the PM Kisan Nidhi Scheme remains unchanged even after seven years'

of Tribal Affairs, and the Ministry of Panchayati Raj have remained "stagnant" for many years.

He also said that the amount paid to farmers under the PM Kisan Nidhi Scheme was Rs 6,000 in 2019, and even after seven years, the amount remains unchanged.

"Shouldn't these be our pri-

orities?" Jha said.

He alleged that the process of issuing Soil Health Cards to farmers is riddled with corruption, but the government, instead of accepting this, continues to "remain in denial".

Claiming that it had adopted a similar "stand of denial" in the field of diplomacy, Jha referred to the reported killing of 175

Suspension of 8 LS MPs likely to be revoked today

NEW DELHI: The suspension of eight Opposition MPs from the Lok Sabha is likely to be revoked on Tuesday, sources said, citing a decision taken at a meeting convened by Speaker Om Birla.

Seven Congress and a CPI(M) MP were suspended for unruly behaviour, following a resolution passed by the Lok Sabha in the first part of the Budget Session.

While the eight MPs were suspended for the entire session that is scheduled to conclude on April 2, Opposition parties have been urging the speaker to revoke the suspensions during one of the sittings of the Lok Sabha.

When Congress members had urged Birla to revoke the suspensions, he had said such action is taken when someone climbs on tables.

The revocation of suspension of the eight MPs has been a key demand of the Opposition since the second leg of the Budget Session commenced on March 9.

The sources said there was a general consensus at the meeting that Opposition members will restrict themselves in the Well of the House and not cross over to the treasury benches.

Tearing papers, climbing on chairs and tables and using AI-generated posters will also be avoided by the Opposition parties to register their protests.

Birla expressed "deep concern" on Sunday over the showing of banners, placards, posters and use of certain language in the House by some MPs, and urged the leaders of all political parties to ensure discipline and high ethical conduct among their members.

BJP releases first list of 47 candidates for Kerala Assembly polls

NEW DELHI/THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Union minister George Kurian and former Union ministers Rajeev Chandrasekhar and V Muraliedharan are among the 47 candidates announced by the BJP in its first list for the Kerala Assembly elections.

Fielding a mix of senior leaders and new faces as it prepares for the April 9 polls, the party is hoping to end its electoral drought in the state, where politics has traditionally been dominated by the CPI(M)-led LDF and the Congress-led UDF.

Among the prominent names in the list are Kurian, Chandrasekhar and Muraliedharan, along with senior leaders K Surendran, Sobha Surendran, P C George, Padmaja Venugopal, P K Krishnadas, former director general of police R Sreelekha and filmmaker Major Ravi.

Chandrasekhar will contest from the Nemom Assembly constituency, while Muraliedharan has been fielded from Kazhakoottam, both key constituencies in Thiruvananthapuram district.

Nemom is the only constituency in Kerala that has so far been won by the BJP, when O Rajagopal won the seat in the 2016 Assembly election.

The BJP has now fielded its state president Chandrasekhar from Nemom, hoping to regain the seat in the election.

Kurian will contest from the Kanjirappally constituency in Kottayam district. The seat is considered significant for the BJP as it seeks to expand its presence in Christian-dominated central Kerala constituencies in the election.

Veteran politician George will contest from the Poonjar Assembly constituency in Kottayam district, while Surendran is contesting from the Manjeshwar constituency in Kasaragod district.

Sreelekha has been nominated from Vattiyookavu in Thiruvananthapuram, while Padmaja Venugopal will contest from Thrissur.



EXPERTS RAISE CONCERNS

Centre proposes separate bodies to fast-track environmental nods

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: As the Centre has proposed setting up standing bodies to expedite the green clearance process in states and Union territories, experts have raised concerns about the criteria for selecting the members for the new bodies, saying it could lead to a weakened scrutiny of projects.

According to a draft notification issued on March 5, the new bodies would assume the functions of the existing State Environment Impact Assessment Authorities (SEIAA) and State Expert Appraisal Committees (SEAC) whenever these state-level institutions become non-functional due to the expiry of their tenures or delays in reconstitution.

While the SEIAA grants environmental clearances, the SEAC advises it in appraising the project.

The new bodies - Standing Authority on Environment Impact Assessment (SAEIA) and Standing Committee on Environment Impact Appraisal

Key Points

- » While the SEIAA grants environmental clearances, the SEAC advises it in appraising the project

(SCEIA) - would comprise "ex officio members", meaning government officials or bureaucrats, nominated by the Central government.

Subhrajit Goswami, a researcher with the Centre for Science and Environment, told news agency, "This move bypasses the legal mandate of Appendix VI (Environment Impact Assessment Notification, 2006), which requires that both the chairman and members possess significant domain experience, such as being 'eminent' experts with 15 years of experience or a PhD in relevant fields."

"Administrative oversight often emphasises the 'ease of doing business' metrics, which may overlook site-specific eco-

- » New bodies - Standing Authority on Environment Impact Assessment and Standing Committee on Environment Impact Appraisal - would comprise 'ex officio members'

logical nuances that a seasoned botanist or environmental engineer would typically flag," he added.

Speaking to news agency, Nawnet Vibhaw, a professor at the Jindal Global Law School, said that while ex officio members may possess the technical knowledge or expertise required for addressing issues like green clearance, the eligibility criteria had not been clearly defined in the draft notification.

"However, there is a requirement for showing that such officials do not have a conflict of interest in dealing with such projects. This has been done to allay fears of bias and avoid any kind of conflict of interest," he said.

Currently, in the absence of an SEIAA or SEAC, the central level Expert Appraisal Committee (EAC) manages the workload.

According to the draft notification, this is an issue as it "leads to a complete halt in the EC (environment clearance) process at the state level and the pending proposals are transferred in bulk to the Centre, leading to extended timelines and unwarranted delays in the appraisal of the projects, thereby impacting project timelines and investor confidence".

Goswami, however, said the involvement of the EAC ensured that projects remain under the scrutiny of domain specialists across fields, such as ecosystem management, air and water pollution control, and risk assessment.

"By substituting these statutory experts with a standing committee of officials, the process loses the legal guarantee of scientific temperament and technical integrity currently protected by law," he added.

NEW DELHI: The Rajya Sabha will function on the weekend on March 28-29 as the government has accepted the request of some members not to hold sittings on March 19-20 on account of festivals, Chairman C P Radhakrishnan informed members on Monday.

During a meeting of the Business Advisory Committee held on March 11, 2026, certain members had suggested that in view of several festivals such as Navaratri, Gudipadwa, Ramadan etc, starting from March 19, it would be inappropriate to hold sittings of the House.

"I wish to inform the members that the request made in this regard has been considered favourably by the government. Accordingly, the sittings of the Council scheduled for Thursday, 19 March 2026, and Friday, 20 March 2026, stands cancelled.

"However, in order to make up for the time so lost, the Council will instead sit on Saturday, 28 March 2026, and Sunday, 29 March 2026. Members may kindly take note of the same," the Rajya Sabha Chairman said.

Nation Briefs

ASSAM ASSEMBLY POLLS: CPI(M) NAMES CANDIDATES FOR 2 SEATS

GUWAHATI: The CPI(M), a part of the Congress-led opposition alliance in Assam, on Monday named candidates for two seats for the Assembly polls in April, retaining incumbent MLA Manoranjan Talukdar among its nominees. State CPI(M) secretary Suprakash Talukdar asserted that it was confident of winning both the seats in the elections scheduled for April 9. "We have decided to contest in two seats - Bhawanipur-Sorbhog and Goreswar. Our nominees will be the united opposition's candidates in both constituencies," Talukdar said. Manoranjan Talukdar, the MLA from Bhawanipur in the outgoing Assembly, will be contesting from Bhawanipur-Sorbhog, after the constituency was renamed and redrawn during the delimitation process in 2023.

FORMER MINISTER GHARU RAM RE-JOINS CONGRESS IN JAMMU

JAMMU: Former minister Gharu Ram on Monday rejoined the Congress along with his supporters here, pledging to work for strengthening the party at the grassroots level, a party spokesman said. Jammu and Kashmir PCC chief Tariq Hameed Karra, working president Raman Bhalla and president of District Congress Committee (Jammu Rural) Neeraj Kundan warmly welcomed Ram into the party fold. Ram had joined the Democratic Progressive Azad Party (DPAP) ahead of the 2024 Assembly elections in the Union Territory.







EDITORIAL
GEOPOLITICS
OF HORMUZ

The Strait of Hormuz has long been the world's most sensitive energy chokepoint, a narrow stretch of water whose strategic importance far exceeds its physical size. Roughly a fifth of the global oil supply and a significant portion of liquefied natural gas pass through this corridor between Iran and Oman each day. Now, after the February 28 U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran and the subsequent escalation in hostilities, Tehran has effectively rendered the strait unsafe for commercial shipping through drones, missiles and naval mines. The result is not merely a regional security crisis but a moment that threatens the stability of the global economy. U.S. President Donald Trump's demand that allied nations help reopen the waterway reflects the urgency of the situation, yet assembling a coalition fleet will not easily restore normalcy. The Strait of Hormuz is not simply a maritime route that can be cleared by naval power. It is a geopolitical pressure point where military capability, geography and political calculation intersect in ways that make even the strongest coalition cautious.

Iran's decision to disrupt traffic through the strait must be understood in the context of the broader conflict now unfolding in the region. For decades, Iranian leaders have threatened to close the passage whenever tensions with the West intensified. Those warnings were often dismissed as rhetorical leverage, since Iran itself exports large quantities of oil through the same corridor. Blocking the strait would ordinarily harm Tehran's own economic interests and invite severe retaliation. Yet the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader in the recent strikes has transformed the strategic equation. Iranian officials now frame the conflict as existential, and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps appears to be shaping military strategy with a greater sense of urgency and defiance. In such circumstances, the calculus shifts from economic rationality to political survival. When states believe their regime is under existential threat, they are more willing to employ measures that previously seemed too risky or self-destructive. The disruption of the Strait of Hormuz is therefore not merely a tactical move but a signal that Iran is prepared to escalate the conflict in ways that impose global costs.

The consequences of such escalation are already becoming visible. Oil prices have surged in international markets, raising fears of another inflationary shock similar to the one triggered by Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022. Energy prices remain a powerful driver of global economic instability, and sustained disruptions in Gulf exports would quickly ripple through supply chains across continents. The impact would not be confined to fuel alone. Around one-third of the world's fertilisers—particularly sulphur and ammonia—also move through the Strait of Hormuz, meaning that prolonged instability could affect agricultural production and food prices worldwide. For developing economies already struggling with high inflation and currency pressures, a prolonged energy shock could prove devastating. The last time the world witnessed such disruption on a comparable scale was during the oil crises of the 1970s, when geopolitical tensions in the Middle East triggered economic recessions across much of the industrialised world. Today's global economy, deeply interconnected and energy dependent, is no less vulnerable to such shocks.

Despite the urgency, reopening the strait is far easier said than done. The geography of the waterway itself heavily favours Iran. Shipping lanes are only about two nautical miles wide in each direction, forcing massive oil tankers to navigate predictable routes close to Iranian territory and islands. This makes them vulnerable to a variety of asymmetric tactics that the Revolutionary Guards have refined over decades. Even though Iran's conventional navy is relatively limited, it retains an extensive arsenal of tools designed specifically for maritime disruption: fast attack boats, naval mines, mini-submarines and an expanding fleet of drones capable of harassing or striking vessels. These capabilities do not need to sink ships to be effective. Simply making the route appear unsafe can deter shipping companies and insurers from allowing tankers to pass through the area. Escorting commercial vessels with warships may work temporarily, but sustaining such operations for months would require enormous naval resources and constant vigilance against unconventional attacks, including suicide operations by small craft. Recent experience in the Red Sea offers a cautionary precedent. Despite extensive U.S. and European naval patrols, Yemen's Houthi rebels managed to disrupt shipping routes for over two years, forcing many companies to divert vessels around Africa rather than risk attack. Iran, with far greater resources and technological capacity, would be an even more formidable adversary.

Trump's call for allied warships reflects the recognition that no single country can manage the security challenge alone. The United States has begun discussing escort operations with several partners and has offered insurance guarantees to shipping companies to encourage continued trade through the Gulf. Britain has signalled willingness to coordinate options with allies, while France has suggested that a broader multinational mission could eventually emerge. Yet the responses of other countries reveal the limits of enthusiasm for direct involvement. Germany has expressed scepticism about expanding naval operations, while Japan and Australia have indicated they are unlikely to deploy warships. Even the European Union's existing maritime mission in the Red Sea remains limited in scope. These hesitant reactions underline a difficult reality: while many countries depend heavily on Gulf energy supplies, few are eager to be drawn into a direct military confrontation with Iran.

Ultimately, the crisis surrounding the Strait of Hormuz illustrates the fragile architecture of global energy security. The world economy continues to rely heavily on a handful of geographic chokepoints whose stability depends on political conditions in volatile regions. Naval coalitions may temporarily restore shipping flows, but they cannot eliminate the deeper strategic tensions that repeatedly threaten these routes. Long-term stability will require not only diplomatic engagement to reduce regional conflict but also broader efforts to diversify energy supply chains and reduce dependence on vulnerable transit corridors. For now, however, the world faces a more immediate challenge. If the Strait of Hormuz remains blocked for an extended period, the consequences will extend far beyond the Gulf. Energy markets will tighten, food prices could rise, and global economic uncertainty will deepen. The narrow waterway between Iran and Oman has once again reminded the world how easily geopolitical conflict can disrupt the arteries of the global economy.

CONFLICT
WATCH



BHARAT BHUSHAN
BABU AREKATLA

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IIS
OFFICER OF THE
1991 BATCH, WHO
HAD SERVED IN THE
MIDDLE EAST FOR
SEVEN YEARS

The arguments
used to justify
the strikes on Iran
lack convincing
logic when seen
against available
international
evidence

The US-Israel strikes on Iran raise serious legal, political and strategic questions, threatening international law and destabilising an already fragile Middle East

U S-Israel combined strikes on Iran on February 28, which led to the death of the Supreme Leader of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and several others, including the country's Defence Minister and IRGC commanders, have neither the approval of the US Congress nor the United Nations. Several US lawmakers have questioned the legality of President Trump's war on Iran. It severely sets back the progress made in international humanitarian law since the end of World War II and puts forth an argument for resorting to the jungle law that 'might is right'.

There is also a question of whose war it is—many analysts believe it was primarily Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu who, during the six trips that he had made to Washington in Trump's second term since January 2025, managed to convince the American President to carry out what is mainly an Israeli agenda in Iran, which is regime change. There is nothing secret about it. Netanyahu has been saying that it was his dream for 40 years to change the Iranian regime. Many of the Gulf States believe that Israel wants to be a regional hegemon by obliterating any challenge—previously from Hamas in Gaza, Hizbollah in Lebanon and, now, Iran.

As for President Trump, the objective of the current war keeps altering every day, like the day's temperature. If one day it is regime change, the next day it is eliminating the nuclear threat from Iran, and then further on it is that the US had to strike Iran to pre-empt it from launching attacks on the US. Under sanctions for decades, with the armed prowess of its proxies, Hamas and



Escalation in the Middle East exposes shifting geopolitical ambitions and the fragile foundations of international law

Hezbollah severely degraded, Tehran was hardly in a position to pose any significant threat to the US except for the oral harangues during Friday sermons. Specifically on the nuclear threat posed by Iran, Mr Rafael Mariano Grossi, DG, IAEA (International Atomic Energy Agency), who has oversight powers on the Iranian nuclear programme, said as recently as March 8 that there was no evidence that Iran was currently making a nuclear bomb. Seen in this backdrop, the arguments of the US to justify Iran strikes at the current juncture lack convincing logic.

There is no doubt that Israel has developed huge capabilities both in intelligence and military technology ever since its inception in 1948 to keep at bay the perceived threats from Palestinian groups and neighbouring Arab countries. It has mastered these capabilities by targeting Palestinian groups both in the West

Bank and Gaza for years. But the question is whether it has achieved the much sought-after objective of "peace" for its citizens, or peace in the neighbourhood.

Regarding Iran, Israel knows very well that Tehran does not have the capabilities to threaten Tel Aviv's existence. This gives credence to the argument that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu is using the current situation to strengthen his own position domestically. In the current conflict, Israel is firing from US shoulders. It has provided all the intelligence, and President Trump and other leaders of his administration were persuaded to take up this so-called once-in-a-lifetime opportunity for regime change in Iran and go down in history. No American President since Jimmy Carter, after the 1979 revolution in Iran, could achieve this feat. PM Netanyahu succeeded by stoking the vanity of Presi-

dent Trump. Their claim that Iran is on the verge of going nuclear has to be taken with a grain of salt. Remember, similar claims were made about Saddam Hussein as well before the invasion of Iraq in 2003.

Trump says Iran is a terrorist country. If at all, it is not Iran but Pakistan that fits the description to a T and should have been the target of the US-Israel action if they were really interested in fighting terrorism.

Even for those reformists in Iran who have been resisting the hardliner regime for decades, and who have spent years behind bars for speaking up, these events are not welcome. One reformist leader said they were both happy and sad—happy because the hardliners who humiliated the reformists for years are themselves being humiliated now, and sad to see the massive destruction of their country and the price that ordinary Iranians have had to pay.

As for the rest of the world, the ripples of the war have been felt in many ways, but the most significant impact has been in terms of the rise in crude oil prices. Many countries have resorted to curtailing consumption, hiking prices of oil products, and returning to work-from-home arrangements to battle shortages. They are also trying to ensure the safety of their citizens in Gulf countries and making efforts to evacuate them to safer places.

From all these perspectives, it is very difficult to reach any logical conclusion as to whose interests are being served in the current conflict. It has to end immediately to contain any further destabilising effects in the region as well as the rest of the world.

Views expressed are personal

FAULTLINES



SHANTONU SEN

THE WRITER IS A
FORMER JOINT
DIRECTOR
OF THE CBI

The rule of law
depends not only
on statutes and
institutions but on
the courage of
individuals and
the integrity of
systems. When
corruption
infiltrates
networks of
power, justice
itself becomes
vulnerable

The Patronage Behind Crime

Organised crime rarely operates alone; it survives through political protection, financial channels and administrative facilitation that allow criminal networks to function with impunity

In the long and complex history of India's struggle against organised crime and terrorism, few episodes illustrate the entanglement of crime, politics and institutional fragility as starkly as an insider's account of an investigation conducted in the turbulent years following the Bombay serial blasts of 1993. It exposes how corruption and political patronage can undermine even the most painstaking law enforcement efforts.

The narrative begins with a dramatic operation on 23 July 1993, when a Crime Branch team of the Delhi Police apprehended five armed members of Dawood Ibrahim's gang travelling in two Toyota vehicles. The men carried pistols, grenades and button knives. Their arrest suggested the imminent execution of a terrorist act. What followed was an extensive investigation that was later transferred to the Central Bureau of Investigation, the Special Task Force (STF) of which I was the Joint Director. We gradually uncovered a network of criminal collaboration and protection extending far beyond the underworld.

The investigation revealed a disturbing reality about organised crime. Criminal networks rarely operate in isolation. They often depend upon structures of protection and patronage that extend into political authority, administrative machinery and corporate institutions. Evidence collected during the investigation indicated that the gang members who had been apprehended were supported by individuals occupying positions of influence in politics and business.

Among those whose names surfaced during the investigation were Kalpnath Rai, then Union Minister of State for Power; Brij Bhushan Saran Singh, a BJP Member of Parliament; and Saboo V. Chackoo, the regional manager of East West Airlines, a relation of Rajiv Gandhi's associate called George. These individuals were alleged to have acted as protectors, facilitators or financial conduits for members of the Dawood Ibrahim network operating in the national capital.

The investigation also revealed the troubling intersection between organised crime and corporate structures. East West Airlines, a prominent private airline of the time, was found to have been involved in providing financial channels linked to the criminal network. The trial court imposed a fine of Rs 50 lakhs on the company for its role in the case. The episode illustrated how corporate institutions, when compromised by influence or intimidation, can become instruments within criminal ecosystems.

More alarming was the discovery of systematic shelter provided to gang members within Delhi. Investigators documented that certain accused had stayed in government guest houses for



Investigations following the 1993 Bombay blasts exposed connections between organised crime networks, political patronage and corporate facilitation

extended periods without paying for accommodation, food or other services. According to the investigation, these expenses were ultimately settled through ministerial influence. Such arrangements suggested that the hospitality extended to these individuals was not accidental but part of a broader system of protection that allowed organised criminals to operate in the capital with confidence.

This network of patronage revealed a deeper form of corruption that often escapes simple legal categorisation. Corruption in such circumstances is not confined to direct bribery or illicit payments. It manifests through protection, influence, facilitation and deliberate inaction. Criminal organisations flourish when political authority, administrative discretion and financial resources converge to shield them from accountability.

The trial before the Special TADA Court validated the work of the investigators of the STF. After examining numerous witnesses, analysing documentary evidence and conducting detailed questioning under Section 313 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, the court convicted several accused under provisions of the Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act, the Arms Act and criminal conspiracy laws.

The judgment represented the culmination of months of investigation and prosecutorial effort.

However, the subsequent judicial proceedings in the Supreme Court of India produced outcomes that generated considerable controversy. Certain individuals alleged to have provided financial support, shelter and logistical assistance to the gang were acquitted. The reasoning rested largely on the conclusion that the prosecution had not established the necessary mens rea, or guilty intent (which the trial court had found in abundance), required to sustain convictions under the anti-terrorism law.

For the investigators involved in the case, this reasoning appeared deeply problematic. The evidence collected during the investigation suggested a sustained association between political figures, corporate actors and members of Dawood Ibrahim's network. Financial records, witness testimonies and documented hospitality arrangements were believed to have demonstrated a pattern of protection that enabled criminal networks to operate within Delhi.

The case, therefore, raises broader questions about the nature of corruption in complex criminal systems. Corruption rarely appears in dramatic or easily identifiable forms. More often,

it operates quietly through networks of mutual benefit. Protection is exchanged for loyalty, financial flows sustain influence, and silence becomes a form of complicity. In such circumstances, the boundary between legitimate authority and criminal collaboration becomes dangerously blurred.

The narrative illustrates the structural challenges faced by investigative agencies. Criminal conspiracies involving political influence and corporate structures rarely produce straightforward evidence. They rely on informal arrangements, coded communications and relationships of convenience. Establishing criminal intent beyond a reasonable doubt becomes extraordinarily difficult when those involved possess power, resources and institutional access.

Yet the investigation itself remains significant for what it revealed. Months of meticulous work by investigators uncovered a network connecting gang members, political figures and corporate actors. Even where prosecutions faltered, the investigation illuminated the complex ecosystems through which organised crime sustains itself. This transcends the story of a single criminal case. It becomes a reflection on institutional vulnerability and the enduring challenge of combating corruption within democratic systems. The episode demonstrates how organised crime can thrive when political patronage, corporate complicity and administrative discretion intersect.

The lessons from this narrative remain relevant even decades later. Combating corruption requires more than the enforcement of criminal law. It demands institutional transparency, political integrity, independent investigative mechanisms and a vigilant public culture that refuses to tolerate the misuse of power.

My account serves as both documentation and a warning. It shows how criminal networks may embed themselves within structures of influence and how difficult it becomes to disentangle them once such networks take root. At the same time, it underscores the importance of determined investigators who persist in pursuing the truth even when confronted by powerful interests.

Ultimately, the story is not merely about events from the early 1990s. It is about a persistent challenge faced by democratic societies everywhere. The rule of law depends not only on statutes and institutions but on the courage of individuals and the integrity of systems. When corruption infiltrates networks of power, justice itself becomes vulnerable. The narrative reminds us that vigilance against such corruption is not merely desirable but essential for the survival of the rule of law.

Views expressed are personal

CARGO SHIPS ARE STUCK IN THE GULF

European Union weighs action to keep Strait of Hormuz open

BRUSSELS: The European Union said on Monday it will consider how to help keep the Strait of Hormuz open as energy and commodity prices rise in the third week of war between Iran, Israel and the United States.

"It is in our interest to keep the Strait of Hormuz open, and that's why we are also discussing what we can do in this regard from the European side," said Kaja Kallas, the EU's foreign policy chief, ahead of a meeting of the 27-nation bloc's foreign ministers in Brussels on Monday.

US President Donald Trump has asked allies - including France, China, Japan, South Korea and Britain - to help secure the strait for global shipping.

Kallas said the EU could expand its Aspides naval mission to protect shipping in the Red Sea up into the Persian Gulf, or it could form a "coalition of the willing" with member nations contributing military capacity on an ad hoc basis.



Protesters shout slogans against Donald Trump's demands to multiple countries to send warships to keep the Strait of Hormuz open, near the U.S. Embassy in Seoul on Monday

The war in Iran, sparked on Feb. 28, airstrikes by Israel and the US, has driven up energy prices worldwide, with Brent crude up more than 40 per cent.

But the conflict has also

disrupted the wider global supply chain beyond oil, affecting everything from pharmaceuticals from India, semiconductors from Asia and oil-derived products like fertilisers that come from the

Middle East.

Cargo ships are stuck in the Gulf or making a much longer detour around the southern tip of Africa.

Planes carrying air cargo out of the Middle East are

German Foreign Minister Johann
Wadepuhl said it will be important for the US and Israel to define when they consider the military aims of their deployment to have been reached

grounded.

And the longer the war drags on, the more likely it is that there will be shortages and price increases on a wide range of goods.

France has said it is working with countries - President Emmanuel Macron mentioned partners in Europe, India and Asia - on a possible international mission to escort ships through the strait, but has stressed it must be when "the circumstances permit," when fighting has subsided.

China calls for halt to military ops after Trump's push to secure Hormuz

BEIJING: China on Monday called on all countries to immediately stop military operations in West Asia in response to US President Donald Trump's appeal to help keep the Strait of Hormuz open for international transport, ruling out Beijing joining any international naval force risking its close ties with Iran.

The effective closure of the vital waterway by Iran in retaliation for airstrikes by the US and Israel has proved catastrophic for global energy and trade flows, causing the largest oil supply disruption and soaring global oil prices.

China also said it is in talks with the US about Trump's planned visit to Beijing later this month, amid the US President's assertion that he may delay his China trip due to the Iran war.

About Trump's call to China and other countries to join, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian virtually ruled out Beijing's participation in the naval armada to ensure safe passage of ships out of the Strait of Hormuz.

"The recent tense situation in the Strait of Hormuz and waters nearby has impacted the route for international goods and energy trade, disrupting peace and stability in the region and



Chinese President Xi Jinping



US President Donald Trump

Key Points

- » The effective closure of waterway by Iran in retaliation for strikes by the US and Israel has proved catastrophic for global energy and trade flows
- » 'China is in communication with relevant parties to work for the de-escalation of the situation'

BOTH BEIJING AND WASHINGTON ARE IN TALKS ABOUT THE US PRESIDENT'S VISIT

beyond," Lin told a media briefing while answering questions on Trump's appeal.

Instead, he said, "China once again calls on parties to immediately stop military operations, avoid further escalation of the tense situation and prevent regional turmoil from further impacting the global economy".

He, however, said China is in "communication with relevant parties to work for the de-escalation of the situation".

On Trump's comment that

he may delay his visit to China at the end of the month, apparently linking his visit to Beijing's response to his appeal to help keep the Strait of Hormuz open, Lin said both Beijing and Washington are in talks about the US President's visit.

China and the United States are in communication with each other regarding Trump's visit to China, Lin said, adding that the head-of-state diplomacy plays an irreplaceable strategic leading role in China-US relations.

FIGHTING STRETCHES INTO 3RD WEEK Pakistani mortars killed 2 children: Afghanistan



People attend the funeral prayers of police officers, killed in the roadside bomb explosion in Pakistan

KABUL: Afghanistan's Taliban forces and Pakistan's military exchanged fire at multiple locations along their shared border, killing at least two children and wounding 10 people in southeastern Afghanistan, Afghan officials said Monday, as fighting continued for a third consecutive week despite international calls for a ceasefire.

Ten people were also injured when mortar shells fired from Pakistan overnight struck villages in Afghanistan's Khost province, said Mustaghfar Gurbaz, a spokesman for the provincial governor. He said several homes were destroyed.

The latest violence came a day after Pakistan said a mortar fired from Afghanistan hit a house in the northwestern Bajaur district, killing four

members of the same family and wounding two others, including a 5-year-old child.

Residents in Bajaur and officials said the military on Monday targeted Afghan positions along the border, where Sunday's attack originated, and caused heavy losses.

There was no immediate comment from Afghanistan.

The cross-border clashes, which have included multiple Pakistani airstrikes on Afghanistan's capital, Kabul, are among the deadliest between the two neighbours in recent years.

Islamabad has described the situation as an "open war". Pakistan's President Asif Ali Zardari said Afghanistan's Taliban administration crossed a "red line" by deploying drones that injured several civilians in Pakistan last week.

Trump admin's mass deportation agenda at crossroads with Homeland Security shake-up

WASHINGTON: The Department of Homeland Security will soon be under new management, an opportunity to reset President Donald Trump's immigration agenda or to double down on his signature campaign promise to conduct the largest deportation operation in American history.

The White House's political director recently encouraged party lawmakers during a retreat at the Republican president's golf club in Florida to focus on immigration enforcement against criminals, a pivot from the mass deportation agenda he ran on.

“NOBODY IS CHANGING THE ADMINISTRATION'S IMMIGRATION ENFORCEMENT AGENDA”

House Speaker Mike Johnson said the aggressive operations have created a "hiccup" for the party, which is now embarking on a "course correction."

Yet all indications are that Trump's mass depor-

tation operation is not stalling out but intensifying, with billions of dollars being spent to hire Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers, build warehouse detention sites and meet the administration's goal of rounding up and removing some 1 million immigrants from the US this year.

"We are at an interesting moment where it has been an inflection point — the public has finally seen what mass detention and mass deportation mean," said Sarah Mehta, who tracks the issue at the American Civil Liberties

Union.

"This is not an agency that's slowing down," she said. "They're really going forward with some of the cruelest policies."

White House spokeswoman Abigail Jackson said the president's policies have sent immigrants out of the US, either through forced deportations or on their own, and sealed up the US-Mexico border.

"Nobody is changing the administration's immigration enforcement agenda," she said.

Senators ready to grill Trump's DHS nominee over deportations.

'Religious freedom conditions in India continued to deteriorate in last year'

NEW YORK: A US federal government commission has flagged the alleged worsening of religious freedom in India and called for it to be designated as a "Country of Particular Concern".

There were no immediate comments from India on the report issued by the US Commission for International Religious Freedom (USCIRF). In the past few years, India rejected the USCIRF reports as "biased and politically motivated".

In its annual report, the USCIRF also asked that targeted sanctions be imposed

'In the past few years, India rejected the USCIRF reports as biased and politically motivated'

on individuals and entities, such as the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), for their "responsibility and tolerance of severe violations of religious freedom by freezing

those individuals' or entities' assets and/or barring their entry into the United States."

It recommended to the US Government that India be designated as a "country of particular concern," or CPC, for "engaging in and tolerating systematic, ongoing, and egregious religious freedom violations". The report said that in 2025, religious freedom conditions in India continued to deteriorate as the government introduced and enforced new legislation targeting religious minority communities and their houses of worship.

Pakistan reported over 3,600 child abuse cases in 2025: Report

ISLAMABAD: At least 3,630 child abuse cases were reported across Pakistan in 2025, marking an 8 per cent increase from the year before that, according to data released by a non-profit organisation on Monday.

Sahil, an Islamabad-based entity which monitors violence against children and women, said in a statement that the cases had been reported in 81 different newspapers from across the four provinces, as well as Islamabad Capital Territory (ICT), and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) and the Gilgit-Baltistan (GB) region.

"In the year 2025, a total



number of 3,630 child abuse cases have been reported in 81 different newspapers," according to the organisation.

It said that gender divide analysis shows that out of the total reported cases of child abuse, 1,924 (53 per cent) of victims were girls, 1,625 (47 per cent) were boys, and 116 cases were of newborn babies.

The data reveals that in a

day, more than nine children were abused in the year 2025.

The cases of child abuse have increased by 8 per cent (266 children) as compared to the year 2024, it said.

Abduction was the most commonly reported category, with 1,107 cases, followed by sodomy with 596 cases and rape with 522. Other reported categories included 365 cases of missing children, 195 cases of attempted rape, 141 cases of attempted sodomy, 130 cases of gang sodomy, 108 cases of gang rape, 58 cases of murder after sexual abuse, and 53 cases of child marriage.

BBC asks US court to dismiss Trump's \$10 bn defamation suit

LONDON: The BBC filed a motion Monday asking a US court to dismiss President Donald Trump's \$10 billion lawsuit against it.

The British national broadcaster said that the Florida court where the case is expected to be heard does not have jurisdiction over it. It also argued that Trump could not show that it intended to misrepresent him.

Trump filed a lawsuit in December over the way a BBC documentary edited a speech he gave on Jan. 6, 2021. The claim seeks \$5 billion in damages for defamation and a further \$5 billion for unfair trade practices. Last month a judge at the federal court of Florida provisionally set a trial date for February 2027. The BBC argued that the case should be thrown out because the documentary was never aired in Florida or the US. "We have therefore challenged jurisdiction of the Florida court and filed a motion to dismiss the president's claim," the corporation said in a statement.

Politically charged awards season ends with some at Oscars advocating for peace in Gaza

The content of Sunday's ceremony proved more political than previous years

LOS ANGELES: A few artists protested more than just the Trump administration's immigration policies on Hollywood's biggest night.

The presence of "BE GOOD" and "ICE OUT" pins at the Academy Awards paled in comparison to last month's Grammys. But those who did wear protest apparel used Sunday's red carpet to also advocate for Palestinian liberation and a ceasefire amid the fragile situation in Gaza, adding to the growing artist-driven activism at entertainment awards shows.

"No to war and free Palestine," actor Javier Bardem said onstage before presenting best international feature film. He wore a patch reading "No a la Guerra", the same anti-war slogan he sported to protest the Iraq war more than two decades ago.

As Hollywood's awards season comes to a close with the Oscars, political organisers suggested that celebrities found their political voices more this cycle than in recent years.

Maremoto executive direc-



Oscar statue replicas being displayed on the street near the Dolby Theatre in Los Angeles

tor Jess Morales Rocketto, whose Latino advocacy group was behind the immigration pins that debuted at the Golden Globes, called it a "return to form" for artists' political engagement.

She credited comments by Mark Ruffalo on the Golden Globes red carpet in January. The actor, who is often outspoken, told Entertainment Tonight that "as much as I love all this" he found it difficult to pretend "like this crazy stuff isn't happening".

"I think we tapped into

something early on that this is a time to take stands and make clear where you are at this moment in history," Morales Rocketto said ahead of Sunday's Oscars.

On Sunday, attendees representing "The Voice of Hind Rajab" wore a new red "Artists4Ceasefire" pin. The documentary, which follows efforts to rescue a Palestinian girl killed in Gaza, was nominated for best international feature film.

Israeli strikes have killed hundreds of Palestinians since a US-brokered truce went into

effect in October, according to Gaza's Health Ministry.

"Our struggles are connected. So is our liberation. And we're so, so honoured to be here tonight," Saja Kilani, one of the film's stars, told The Associated Press on the red carpet.

The content of Sunday's ceremony proved more political than previous years — even if it lacked direct references to the Iran war and other global issues.

"One Battle After Another" director Paul Thomas Ander-

son said he wrote the political drama for his children to apologise for the "housekeeping mess we left in this world we're handing off to them."

Host Conan O'Brien cracked jokes at the expense of the US health care system and Kid Rock, referring to conservative organisation Turning Point USA's alternative Super Bowl halftime show.

In a rare moment of sincerity, O'Brien said the Oscars are particularly resonant in "moments like these", nodding broadly at the many different world crises.

"We pay tribute tonight not just to film, but to the ideals of global artistry, collaboration, patience, resilience and that rarest of qualities today: optimism," he said.

The best documentary category, whose nominees tend to contain more overt political messages, brought more social commentary. David Borenstein, one of the "Mr. Nobody Against Putin" directors, said the documentary is about "how you lose your country."

World Briefs

SL ANNOUNCES 4-DAY WORKING WEEK AS CONTINGENCY MEASURE

COLOMBO: Sri Lanka on Monday announced a four-day working week with every Wednesday a public holiday as a contingency measure for possible fuel shortages in view of the war in West Asia. Currently, the island nation follows a five-day work week. "It was decided to declare every Wednesday a public holiday with effect from March 18," Commissioner General of Essential Services Prabhath Chandrakerthi said. Clarifying that this would not apply to health, ports, water supplies and customs, he said, "It would be applicable to schools, universities and the judiciary." The government expects the private sector to apply the same measure, the commissioner said.

NETANYAHU POSTS FRESH VIDEO AMID SOCIAL MEDIA RUMOURS OF HIS DEATH

JERUSALEM: A day after releasing a video debunking conspiracy theories of his death, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Monday came up with yet another video 'showing he is alive'. In the 90-second video shared on his personal X account, Netanyahu is seen interacting with people in the Jerusalem Hills. "Sticking to the guidelines and winning together," he captioned the video. In the clip, Netanyahu is seen posing for photographs with two girls, both named Shir, asking a woman walking her dog about its breed, and admiring the view of Jerusalem. "How beautiful is Jerusalem. Nothing like Jerusalem," he is heard saying in the video.

WITH MILITARY CONTROLLING MOST SEATS

Myanmar's Parl meets for first time in 5 years

NAYPYITAW: Myanmar opened its first parliamentary session in more than five years on Monday following an election that did not include major opposition parties, ensuring that the ruling military is set to retain a firm grasp on power.

The military blocked Myanmar's last parliament from convening when it seized power from the last legitimately elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi in February 2021, and has governed without a legislature since then. It's touted elections held in late December and January as a step toward the return of democracy.

But the military and its allies hold nearly 90% of the seats in two-chamber parliament, while Myanmar's former ruling National League for Democracy and other major opposition parties were either blocked from running or refused to compete under conditions they deemed unfair.

Delegates wearing traditional attire arrived in the capital, Naypyitaw, on Monday for the opening session of the 373-seat lower house, which convened in the tightly guarded parliamentary complex, newly renovated after



Representational Image

being badly damaged by last year's earthquake.

Security forces sealed roads leading to the parliament, and vehicles were searched for explosives before entering.

The 213-seat upper house is scheduled to open Wednesday, with 14 regional parliaments set to convene two days after that.

A quarter of the 586 seats in the upper and lower houses — 166 seats — were reserved for the military by the military-written constitution, and the military-backed Union Solidarity and Development Party won 339. Twenty-one other

parties won between one and 20 seats each.

The parliament session comes after phased elections were held in December and January in 263 of the country's 330 townships.

Critics described the vote organized by the military government as an effort to legitimize its rule. The 2021 coup triggered widespread opposition that dragged Myanmar into a civil war.

Tom Andrews, a special rapporteur working with the U.N. human rights office, has urged the international community to reject the election

Highlights

- » The military blocked Myanmar's last parliament from convening when it seized power from in February 2021
- » Security forces sealed roads leading to parliament, and vehicles were searched for explosives before entering

results and any power arrangements that follow.

The new Parliament's first task will be to elect a speaker for each house, then elect a president and two vice presidents.

Senior Gen. Min Aung Hlaing, who currently heads the current military government, is widely expected to assume the presidency.

However, the constitution bars a president from serving concurrently as the army's commander-in-chief — Myanmar's most powerful post — raising questions about whether he would relinquish that role.

AGENCIES

Thailand's 'Death Fest' invites visitors to embrace mortality

NONTHABURI: Thailand's "Death Fest" invites people to confront mortality while also offering practical services and spiritual advice for the inevitable.

The unusual fair, now in its second year, has broached the subject that's uncomfortable for many. It's also one of the central teachings of Buddhism, which shapes much of Thailand's culture, about life's unavoidable sufferings: birth, old age, sickness and death.

Sangduan Ngamvinijaroon attended the three-day event on Friday with her mother in Nonthaburi province near Bangkok. She said death used to be a difficult subject for her family, but having spent more than 20 years caring for ill family members, including her husband with a stroke and relatives with cancer, she has witnessed several deaths firsthand and now feels more at ease talking about it.

She said she liked the fair because "it's not just about dying well. It's also about the present moment and taking good care of our lives while we're still here."

The event brought together experts and organisations involved in health care, financial planning, palliative care, funeral services

The event brought together experts and organisations involved in health care, financial planning, palliative care, funeral services and memorial innovations

and memorial innovations. Activities and talks focused not only on preparing for death but also on maintaining quality of life until the final days.

"Death involves everybody. It's not just about you," said Zcongklod Bangyikhan, editor-in-chief of The Cloud magazine and one of the event's lead organisers.

"Instead of wondering what dying will be like, maybe we should think about how to make things easier for the people who remain after we're gone."

One popular exhibit is called "Test Die." Visitors can lie inside coffins of different sizes and styles while looking at themselves in a mirror suspended above. The experience is designed to prompt reflection rather than fear. Office worker Phinudta Seehad said it felt calming.

AGENCIES

- FIGHTING STRETCHES INTO 3RD WEEK -

Poland among world's 20 largest economies

POZNAN: A generation ago, Poland rationed sugar and flour while its citizens were paid one-tenth what West Germans earned. Today its economy has edged past Switzerland to become the world's 20th largest with over \$1 trillion in annual output.

It's a historic leap from the post-Communist ruins of 1989-90 to today's European growth champion that economists say has lessons on how to bring prosperity to ordinary people - and that the Trump administration says should be recognized by Poland's presence at a summit of the Group of 20 leading economies later this year.

The transformation is reflected in people like Joanna Kowalska, an engineer from Poznan, a town of half a million people midway between Berlin and Warsaw.

"I get asked often if I'm missing something by coming back to Poland, and to be honest, I feel it's the other way around," Kowalska said. "We are ahead of the United States in so many areas."

Kowalska works at the Poznan Supercomputing and Networking Center, which is developing the first artificial intelligence factory in Poland and integrating it with a quantum computer, one of 10 on the continent financed by a European Union program.

Kowalska worked for Microsoft in the U.S. after graduating from the Poznan University of Technology in a job

The transformation is reflected in people like Joanna Kowalska, an engineer from Poznan, a town of half a million people midway between Berlin and Warsaw

she saw as a "dream come true." But she missed having a "sense of mission," she said.

"Especially when it comes to artificial intelligence, the technology started developing so rapidly in Poland," Kowalska added. "So it was very tempting to come back."

The guest invitation to the G20 summit is mostly symbolic; no guest country has been promoted to full member since the original G20 met at the finance minister level in 1999, and that would take a consensus decision of all the members. Moreover, the original countries were chosen not just by GDP rank, but by their "systemic significance" in the global economy.

But the gesture reflects a statistical truth: In 35 years - a little less than one person's working lifetime - Poland's per capita gross domestic product rose to \$55,340 in 2025, or 85% of the EU average.

That's up from \$6,730 in 1990, or 38% of the EU average and now roughly equal to Japan's \$52,039.

Artillery attack on Yemen village kills at least 10

CAIRO: An artillery attack on a village in northern Yemen killed at least 10 people, including six children, and wounded more than 30 others, officials said on Monday, while the government blamed Iran-backed Houthi rebels for the shelling.

The Houthis targeted a group of people gathered for iftar, the evening meal that breaks the daily fast during the holy month of Ramadan, in Hajjah province, according to the Information Ministry.

The province is mostly controlled by the Houthis, but some areas are held by Yemen's internationally recognised government, which is based in Aden.

The circumstances of the attack on Sunday were unclear, and Houthi officials declined to comment.

Fighting between the Houthis and government forces has also covered Hajjah since Yemen plunged into civil war in 2014, when the Houthis seized the capital, Sanaa, and much of northern Yemen and forced the government into exile.

A Saudi-led coalition, including the United Arab Emirates, intervened the following year in an attempt to restore the government to power.

AGENCIES

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Kamla Devi, W/o late Pravendra Singh, R/o H.No. 113, near Jawahar Colony, Gurudwara Road, Sector 22, Faridabad, have disinherited my son Chandramohan Singh and daughter-in-law Urmila Bharti, who are beyond my control, from all my movable and immovable properties due to their indecent behavior and threats of implicating me in false cases. If they engage in any transaction or illegal activity with anyone in the future, they will be responsible for it themselves. I and other members of my family will have no responsibility.

		Public Health Engineering Department Public Health Engineering Division, Munger SHORT-TERM TENDER NIT No –07/MUNG/PHED/O&M-PHED/2025-26 National Competitive Bidding (Through e-procurement mode on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)				
Govt. of Bihar		1	Designation and Address of Advertiser	Executive Engineer, P. H. Division, Munger		
		2	Date of issue of Tender Notice	11.03.2026		
		3	Period of sale (downloading) of tender Bid Document	19.03.2026 to 06.04.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. through www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in		
		4	Date, time & place of pre-bid meeting	24.03.26 at 11.30 hrs. hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer of concerned P. H. Division		
		5	Last date and time of receipt (uploading) of tender	06.04.26 up to 16:00Hrs on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in		
		6	Date and time of opening of technical bid	06.04.26 at 16:30Hrs on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in		
		7	Date and time of opening of financial bid	To be informed later after the approval of technical bid.		
9. Details of works:						
NoGro up	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (in Lakh)	Amount of Earnest Money (in Lakh)	Cost of Tender Document (non-refundable) in Rs.	BSEDC Bid Processing Fee (in Rs.)	Completion Period (in months)
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
01	Comprehensive operation and maintenance and Special repair of Ward level Piped Water Supply Schemes (Quality/Non- Quality)based on item rates; constructed by the Public Health Engineering Department including payment to the pump operators, electricity bill for five years.	2483.333	34.84	10000.00	As Applicable	60 Months
Executive Engineer P. H. Division, Munger						
PR. No. 026242 (PHED) 2025-26						
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar						
अगर मन में हो एच.आई.वी. अथवा यौन जनित रोग से जुड़े सवाल तो चुन्क 1097 पर करें कॉल।						

OFFICE OF THE RECOVERY OFFICER DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I, DELHI 4 th FLOOR, JEEVAN TARA BUILDING, PARLIAMENT STREET, NEW DELHI-110001		
SALE PROCLAMATION		
TRC / 42/2022 (RC/273/2019)		Date of Auction Sale: 20/04/2026
PROCLAMATION OF SALE UNDER RULE 38, 52(2) OF SECOND SCHEDULE TO THE INCOME TAX ACT, 1961 READ WITH THE RECOVERY OF DEBTS DUE TO BANK AND FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS ACT, 1993.		
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA Vs. M/S NAMRATA ENTERPRISES		
(CD 1) M/S NAMRATA ENTERPRISES, WZH-16/919, BAPANAGAR, KAROL BAGH, DELHI.		
(CD2) ASHOK KUMAR, 2-C/4, NEW ROHTAK ROAD, KAROL BAGH, NEW DELHI.		
1. Whereas Transfer Recovery Certificate No.42/2022 (R. C. 273/2019) in OA No.103 of 2014 drawn by the Presiding Officer, Debts Recovery Tribunal-I for the recovery of a sum of Rs.21,55,784.00 together with costs and future interest @ 24% p.a., from the date of filing of O.A. i.e. 24/12/2013 till realization and also to pay cost as per certificate, from the debtors together with costs and charges as per recovery certificate.		
2. And whereas the undersigned has ordered the sale of property mentioned in the Schedule below in satisfaction of the said Certificate.		
3. And whereas there will be due there under a sum of Rs.21,55,784.00 together with costs and future interest @ 24% p.a., from the date of filing of O.A. i.e. 24/12/2013, till realization and also to pay cost as per certificate. Notice is hereby given that in absence of any order of postponement, the property / properties as under shall be sold by e-auction and bidding shall take place through "On line Electronic Bidding" through the website https://www.bankauctions.com on 20/04/2026 between 12:00 PM and 01:00 PM with extensions of 5 minutes duration after 01:00 PM, if required.		
4. The description of the property proposed to be e-auctioned is as follows :		
No.	Description of Property	Reserve Price (In Rs.)
1.	Property Bearing No.H-16/919, Out of Kharsa No.670/365 Situated at Village Sidhora Khurd, Bapa Nagar, New Delhi-110005.	Rs.67.00 Lakhs
5.	The EMD shall be paid through Demand Draft / Pay Order in favour of Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi- A/c. T.R.C. No.42/2022 along with self - attested copy of Identity (voter I-card/Driving License/Passport) which should contain the address for future communication and self-attested copy of PAN Card must reach to the Office of the Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi latest by 17/04/2026 before 5:00 PM. The EMD received thereafter shall not be considered. The said deposit be adjusted in the case of successful bidders. The unsuccessful bidder shall take return of the EMD directly from the Registry, DRT-I, Delhi after receipt of such report from e-auction service provider / bank / financial institution on closure of the e-auction sale proceedings.	Rs. 6.70 Lakhs
6.	The envelope containing EMD should be super-scribed "T.R.C. No.42/2022" alongwith the details of the sender i.e. address, e-mail ID and Mobile Number etc.	
7.	Intending bidders shall hold a valid Login ID and Password to participate in the E-Auction email address and PAN Number. For details with regard to Login ID & Password, please contact M/s C - 1 INDIA PVT. LTD., Plot No.68, 3rd Floor, Sector-44, Gurugram-122003, Haryana, India Helpline No. 7291981124/25/26, P. Dharani Krishna, Mobile No.9948182222, Website: https://www.bankauctions.com and Email IDs: support@bankauctions.com; dharaani.p@1india.com	
8.	Prospective bidders are required to register themselves with the portal and obtain user ID/Password well in advance, which is mandatory for bidding in above e-auction from M/s C-1 INDIA PVT. LTD.	
9.	Details of concerned Bank Officers / Helpline Numbers etc. are as under :-	
Name & Designation		Email & Phone Nos.
NAVEEN KUMAR SINGH (Senior Manager)		Mob: 9999210655 E-mail: bmdelb2586@centralbank.bank.in
10. What is proposed to be sold are the rights to which the certificate debtors are entitled in respect of the properties. The properties will be sold along with liabilities, if any. The extent of the properties shown in the proclamation is as per the Recovery Certificate schedule. Recovery Officer shall not be responsible for any variation in the extent due to any reason. The properties will be sold on "As is where is" and "as is what is" condition.		
11. The property can be inspected by prospective bidder(s) before the date of sale for which the above named officer of the bank may be contacted.		
12. The undersigned reserves the right to accept or reject any or all bids if found unreasonable or postpone the auction at any time without assigning any reason.		
13. EMD of unsuccessful bidders will be received by such bidders from the Registry of DRT-I, on identification / production of Identity proof viz. PAN Card, Passport, Voters ID, Valid Driving License or Photo Identity Card issued by Govt. and PSUs. Unsuccessful bidders shall ensure return of their EMD and, if not received within a reasonable time, immediately contact the Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi/ or the Bank.		
14. The sale will be of the property of the above named CDs as mentioned in the schedule below and the liabilities and claims attaching to the said property, so far as they have been ascertained are those specified in the schedule against each lot.		
15. The property will be put up for the sale in the lots specified in the schedule. If the amount to be realized is satisfied by the sale of a portion of the property, the sale shall be immediately stopped with respect to the remainder. The sale also be stopped if, before any lot is knocked down, the arrears mentioned in the said certificate, interest costs (including cost of the sale) are tendered to the officer conducting the sale or proof is given to his satisfaction that the amount of such certificate, interest and costs have been paid to the undersigned.		
16. No officer or other person, having any duty to perform in connection with sale, however, either directly or indirectly bid for, acquire or attempt to acquire any interest in the property sold.		
17. The sale shall be subject to the conditions prescribed in the Second Schedule to the Income Tax Act, 1961 and the rules made there under and to the further following conditions: The particulars specified in the annexed schedule have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned, but the undersigned shall not be answerable for any error, mis-statement or omission in this proclamation.		
18. The amount by which the bidings are to be increased shall be in multiple of Rs.25,000/- (Rupees Twenty Five Thousand Only). In the event of any dispute arising as to the amount of bid, or as to the bidder, the lot shall at once be again put up to auction.		
19. The Successful / Highest bidder shall be declared to be the purchaser of any lot provided that further that the amount bid by him is not less than the reserve price. It shall be in the discretion of the undersigned to decline acceptance of the highest bid when the price offered appears so clearly inadequate as to make it inadvisable to do so.		
20. Successful / Highest bidder shall have to prepare DD / Pay Order for 25% of the sale proceeds favouring Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi, A/c. T. R. C. No.42 / 2022 within 24 hours after close of e-auction and after adjusting the earnest money (EMD) and sending / depositing the same in the office of the Recovery Officer so as to reach within 3 days from the close of e-auction failing which the earnest money (EMD) shall be forfeited.		
21. The successful / Highest Bidder shall deposit, through Demand Draft / Pay Order favouring Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi A/c. T.R.C. 42/2022, the balance 75% of the sale proceeds before the Recovery Officer, DRT-I on or before 15 th Day from the date of sale of the property, exclusive of such day, or if the 15 th day be Sunday or other holiday, then on the first office day after the 15 th day alongwith the poundage fee @ 2% upto Rs.1,000 and @ 1% on the excess of such gross amount over Rs.1000/- in favour of Registrar, DRT-I, Delhi. (In case of deposit of balance amount of 75% through post the same should reach the Recovery Officer as above).		
22. In case of default of payment within the prescribed period, the property shall be resold, after the issue of fresh proclamation of sale. The deposit, after defraying the expenses of the sale, may, if the undersigned thinks fit, be forfeited to the Government and the defaulting purchaser shall forfeit all claims to the property or to any part of the sum for which it may subsequently be sold.		
SCHEDULE OF PROPERTY		
Lot No.	Description of the property to be sold with the names of the co-owners where the property belongs to the defaulter and any other person as co-owners	Revenue assessed upon the property or any part thereof
1.	Property Bearing No.H-16/919, Out of Kharsa No.670/365 Situated at Village Sidhora Khurd, Bapa Nagar, New Delhi-110005.	Details of any encumbrance to which property is liable
		Claims, if any, which have been put forward to the property, and any other known particulars bearing on its nature and value
		No information received.
SEAL OF COURT Given under my hand and seal on 16/02/2026		Sd/- NIRANJAN SHARMA, RECOVERY OFFICER-II, DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-1, DELHI

संचालनालय खेल और युवा कल्याण टी.टी. नगर स्टेडियम, भोपाल (म.प्र.)	
ई-निविदा सूचना	
संचालनालय खेल और युवा कल्याण, मध्यप्रदेश, द्वारा "विभिन्न अकादमियों/खेल परिसर/खेल प्रशिक्षण केन्द्रों हेतु कम्प्यूटर ऑपरेटर, सुरक्षा गार्ड, सफाईकर्मी एवं मेनपाँवर (अकुशल, कुशल, अर्द्ध-कुशल एवं उच्च कुशल) की सेवाएं प्रदान करने हेतु" अधिकृत एजेन्सियों से ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा प्रपत्र व निविदा की विस्तृत शर्तें www.mptenders.gov.in पर उपलब्ध है। ई-निविदा प्रकाशन उपरांत निविदा में कोई संशोधन व परिवर्तन किया जाता है तो वह मात्र उपरोक्त उल्लेखित ई-टेंडर पोर्टल पर ही उपलब्ध रहेगा।	
म.प्र. माध्यम/124943/2026	संचालक

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED	
(See Section 82 Cr. PC)	
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Suraj S/o Lal Rathore R/o H.No. E-777, Savda Colony Kanjhawala Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 185/2019 U/s B-3 at PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Suraj can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Suraj has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Suraj of FIR No. 185/2019 U/s B-3 of PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 17.04.2026.	
By Order Nishat Bangarh Judicial Magistrate First Class-01 (Central) Room No. 180 Tis Hazari Court, Delhi	
DP/3231/CD/2026	

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON	
See Section 82 Cr. P.C.	
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) Rizwan, S/o: Ali Farman R/o: H.No. E-50, Sawda JJ Colony, Ghewra, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 197/22, U/s: 498A/406 IPC, PS: Kanjhawala, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Rizwan, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Rizwan, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Rizwan, of FIR No. 197/22, U/s: 498A/406 IPC, PS: Kanjhawala, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 23.04.2026.	
By Order Aishwarya Sharma Judicial Magistrate First Class Mahila Court-01 (North-West) Room No. 106 First Floor Rohini Court, Delhi	
DP/3284/RD/2026 (Court Matter)	

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON	
See Section 82 CrPC	
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Tony Bansal S/o Ashok Bansal, R/o Vegabond Chandni Chowk, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 1160/21, Dt. 19.12.2021, U/S 392/411/34 IPC, PS Kotwali, North Distt., Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Tony Bansal cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Tony Bansal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant); Proclamation is hereby made that Tony Bansal the said accused of FIR No. 1160/21, Dt. 19.12.2021, U/S 392/411 /34 IPC, PS Kotwali, North Distt., Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 23.04.2026.	
By Order Ms. Sayesha Chadha Judicial Magistrate First Class-08, Central Distt., Room No.-272, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi	
DP/3161/N/2026 (Court Matter)	

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON	
(SEE SECTION 84 BNSS)	
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) Rajesh Seth S/o Rajender Nath Seth Sole Prop. of M/s. S.C. Diamond R/o 2502, 3rd Floor, Gurudwara Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-05 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case CC No./FIR No. 7836/2016 U/s 138 NI Act, PS Barakhamba Road, New Delhi and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Rajesh Seth can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Rajesh Seth has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Rajesh Seth of case CC No./FIR No. 7836/2016 U/s 138 NI Act, PS Barakhamba Road, New Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated 17.04.2026 at 10:00 A.M.	
By Order Sh. Animesh Kumar Judicial Magistrate, First Class-02 Court No. 32, Loc-Up Building Patiala House Courts, New Delhi	
DP/3388/NDD/2026 (Court Matter)	



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: T_24-25_ICF_Coach_Lift/Notice

Date: 13.03.2026

E-Tender Notice

Coach MLR Workshop, Jhansi for and on behalf of the President of India invites open e-tender from reputed contractors for following work:-

Tender No.	Earnest money	Tender doc. cost
T_24-25_ICF_Coach_Lift	Rs. 2,88,600/-	Rs. 0/-

Description of work: Lifting of ICF Coaches, Unloading, Cleaning, Dismantling, Transportation and Filment of ICF-type bogie frames along with tractor trolley with driver and fuel, as per the defined scope of work at CMLR Workshop Jhansi.

Tender cost: Rs. 2,77,09,263.80/- (Rs. Two Crores Seventy-Seven Lakhs Nine Thousand Two Hundred Sixty-Three & Paise Eighty Only)

Qty.: One Work	Completion period: 24 months
----------------	------------------------------

1. Tender will be closed at 15:00 Hrs on 13.04.2026 and is available on Indian Railway E-Tendering website www.ireps.gov.in. 2. For detailed information please visit Indian Railway E-Tendering website www.ireps.gov.in.

3. Tenderers should watch the website for the corrigendum/addendum to the NIT/e-tender document, if any as there will not be any separate communication for the same.

 North central railways

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

 [cprnocr](https://t.me/cprnocr)

587/26 (ADM)

HIGHER CRUDE PRICES TO PUSH WPI HIGHER

Wholesale price inflation rises to 11-month high of 2.13% in Feb

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Wholesale price inflation rose to a 11-month high of 2.13 per cent in February, driven by an uptick in prices of food and non-food articles, even though vegetable prices eased on a month-on-month basis, government data showed on Monday.

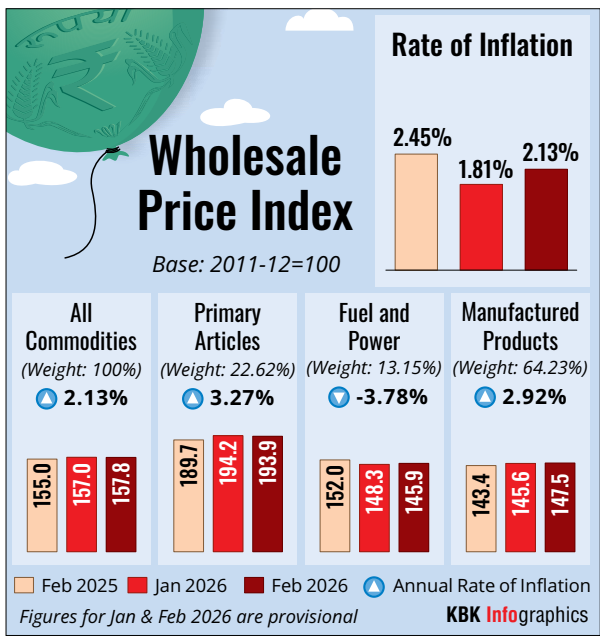
This is the fourth straight month of rise in Wholesale Price Index (WPI)-based inflation. It was 1.81 per cent in January and 2.45 per cent in February last year.

Economists said the WPI inflation is likely to pick up pace further if the oil price rise persists, and spills over to other goods (fertilisers, aluminium) given it tracks international prices more closely relative to the CPI basket.

According to WPI data, inflation in food articles was 2.19 per cent in February, as against 1.55 per cent in the previous month.

Although in vegetables, inflation eased to 4.73 per cent in February against 6.78 per cent in January, pulses, potato and egg, meat and fish saw an uptick in inflation in February.

“Positive rate of inflation in February 2026 is primarily due to an increase in prices of other manufacturing, manufacture of



basic metals, non-food articles, food articles and textiles, etc.,” the industry ministry said in a statement.

Negative inflation, or deflation, in the fuel and power basket narrowed to 3.78 per cent in February, vis-a-vis 4.01 per cent in January. Global oil prices averaged \$68/bbl in February from \$63/bbl in January.

Barclays in a research note said the passthrough of the rise in crude oil prices from

the Middle East conflict will reflect more in WPI inflation vs retail CPI inflation, as retail fuel prices are unchanged in the latter.

“With a sharp jump in crude oil prices crossing \$100/bbl as of 16 March, the corresponding WPI will likely reflect this in the March print,” Barclays said.

India Ratings and Research the rising crude oil prices since the US-Iran war will have a

Highlights

» This is the fourth straight month of rise in Wholesale Price Index (WPI)-based inflation. It was 1.81 per cent in January and 2.45 per cent in February last year

» According to WPI data, inflation in food articles was 2.19 per cent in February, as against 1.55 per cent in the previous month

» Non-food articles category inflation spiked to 8.80 per cent in February, from 7.58 per cent in January

the same for some time, which may negate any sharp jump in retail inflation. However, the increase in crude oil prices will push wholesale inflation higher. Ind-Ra expects wholesale inflation in March to jump to 3.7 per cent,” Pant said.

As per WPI data for February, inflation in manufactured products inched up to 2.92 per cent in February, from 2.86 per cent in the preceding month.

Non-food articles category inflation spiked to 8.80 per cent in February, from 7.58 per cent in January.

PHDCCI President Rajeev Juneja said given the geopolitical risks, a continued policy focus on improving supply-chain efficiencies, lowering logistics costs, supporting domestic manufacturing, and ensuring adequate availability of critical inputs for industry is critical to contain cost-push pressures.

As per data released last week, India’s retail inflation rose to 3.2 per cent in February, from 2.75 per cent in January.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has reduced policy interest rates by 1.25 percentage points in the current fiscal year as inflation remained low. The RBI mainly tracks retail inflation for deciding on benchmark interest rates.

AFTER MASSIVE DRUBBING IN PAST 3 DAYS

Markets rise over 1% on buying in blue-chip banking counters

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded by over 1 per cent on Monday after facing a massive drubbing in the past three trading days, driven by value-buying in blue-chip banking counters.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 938.93 points or 1.26 per cent to settle at 75,502.85. During the day, it hit a high of 75,805.27 and a low of 73,949.76.

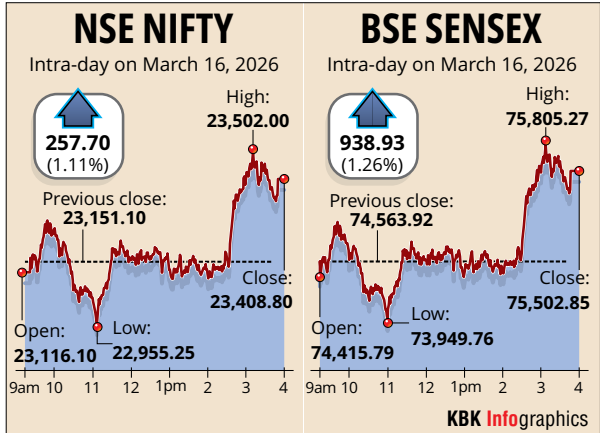
The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 257.70 points or 1.11 per cent to end at 23,408.80.

From the 30 Sensex firms, UltraTech Cement surged 4.22 per cent. Trent, HDFC Bank, Mahindra & Mahindra, Eternal, Bajaj Finance, ITC, Tata Steel and State Bank (SBI) of India were among the biggest gainers.

Bharat Electronics, Sun Pharma, Power Grid and Bharti Airtel were among the major laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index dipped 0.36 per cent and Smallcap Select index edged lower by 0.25 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, BSE Top 10 Banks surged 1.61 per cent, followed by Private Banks index (1.38 per cent), Financial Services (1.32 per cent), Auto (1.23 per cent), Bankex (1.08 per cent) and FMCG (0.94 per cent).



From the 30 Sensex firms, UltraTech Cement, Trent, HDFC Bank, Mahindra & Mahindra, Eternal, Bajaj Finance, ITC, Tata Steel & SBI were among the biggest gainers

BSE oil & gas index dropped 2.29 per cent, hospitals (1.64 per cent), realty (1.51 per cent), energy (1.36 per cent) and healthcare (1.13 per cent).

In Asian markets, Japan’s Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai’s SSE Composite index ended lower, while South

Korea’s benchmark Kospi and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index settled higher. Markets in Europe were trading mostly lower.

The US market ended lower on Friday.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 1.41 per cent to \$104.4 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 10,716.64 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth Rs 9,977.42 crore.

On Friday, the Sensex settled at 74,563.92, down 1,470.50 points or 1.93 per cent. The Nifty tanked 488.05 points or 2.06 per cent to end at 23,151.10.

Unemployment dips marginally to 4.9% in February, says Periodic Labour Force Survey

NEW DELHI: Overall unemployment among persons aged 15 years and above fell marginally to 4.9 per cent in February from 5 per cent in January this year, according to the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) released on Monday.

After an increase in January 2026, the urban unemployment rate (UR) among persons aged 15 years and above declined to 6.6 per cent in February 2026, falling below the December 2025 level (6.7%), the survey stated.

Rural UR remained unchanged at 4.2 per cent in February 2026.

In February 2026, the overall unemployment rate (UR) among females aged 15 years and above declined to 5.1 per cent, compared to 5.6 per cent in January, 2026. Decline was observed in both rural and urban areas.

After a rise in Jan 2026, the urban unemployment rate declined to 6.6% in February 2026

The urban female UR decreased from 9.8 per cent in January 2026 to 8.7 per cent in February 2026, while the rural female UR declined from 4.3 per cent to 4.0 per cent during the same period.

The overall male UR remained stable at 4.8 per cent.

The overall Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) among persons of age 15 years and above remained unchanged at 55.9 per cent in February 2026, the same as recorded in January 2026.

In rural areas, the LFPR stood at 58.7 per cent in Feb-

ruary 2026. The urban LFPR was estimated at 50.4 per cent in February 2026, showing a marginal increase from 50.3 per cent recorded in January 2026.

The overall female LFPR in the age group 15 years and above increased marginally from 35.1 per cent in January 2026 to 35.3 per cent in February 2026.

In rural areas, the female LFPR rose from 39.7 per cent in January 2026 to 40.0 per cent in February 2026, indicating an improvement in rural female participation, whereas the urban female LFPR remained unchanged at 25.5 per cent during the same period.

The Worker Population Ratio (WPR) in the age group 15 years and above remained broadly stable in both rural and urban areas in February 2026.

The overall WPR was esti-

mated at 53.2 per cent in February 2026, in comparison to 53.1 per cent in January 2026. In rural areas, WPR stood at 56.3 per cent in February, 2026.

Similarly, the urban WPR observed as 47.0 per cent in February 2026, compared with 46.8 per cent in January 2026.

The all-India level, the monthly estimates are based on information collected from a total number of 3,74,879 persons surveyed.

The PLFS conducted by National Statistics Office (NSO) is the primary source of data on activity participation and employment and unemployment conditions of the population.

The PLFS survey methodology has been modified from January 2025 to provide monthly and quarterly estimates of labour force indicators for the country. PTI

NEW DELHI: The government will soon come out with a modified Stand-Up India scheme to provide better benefits to SC/ST and women entrepreneurs looking to set up new projects, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday.

Launched in 2016, the Stand-Up India scheme aimed to empower Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), and women entrepreneurs by facilitating bank loans for setting up new enterprises. The scheme expired on March 31, 2025.

Replying to a supplementary question in the Lok Sabha, the Minister said the modified scheme will incorporate lessons learnt in implementation of the original Stand-Up India scheme.

“With studies done by Niti Aayog and others, this scheme



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

Launched in 2016, the Stand-Up India scheme expired on March 31, 2025

is being redrafted and sooner the Cabinet will be given a proposal with which we will launch a new scheme to continue with this Stand-Up which benefitted SC/ST and women

all over the country,” Sitharaman said.

The scheme provided loans between Rs 10 lakh and Rs 1 crore at the lowest applicable rate of the bank for that category, with a repayment period of 7 years with a maximum moratorium of up to 18 months.

On whether the government is planning to increase the loan amount, Sitharaman said, “We are looking at various options for the new scheme.”

To another question why only greenfield projects were being given loans under the Stand-Up India scheme, she said there are several other loan options available to businesses through PM Mudra scheme or SIDBI financing. Besides, there is Startup India scheme, which is for innovative ideas and largely restricted to urban areas. PTI

Rupee falls 10 paise to all-time low of 92.40 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee weakened by 10 paise to settle at a fresh record low of 92.40 against the US dollar on Monday amid surging crude oil prices and incessant withdrawal of foreign funds triggered by geopolitical uncertainties.

The local currency, however, resisted a sharp fall backed by a significant recovery in domestic equity markets amid hopes of the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the local unit opened at 92.44 and touched its lowest-ever intra-day level of 92.47 against the greenback during the session.

The local unit ended the session at 92.40 against the dollar, registering a loss of 10 paise from its previous close.

In the preceding session, the rupee hit its lowest intra-day level of 92.47 before ending at 92.30 against the dollar, its lowest-ever closing level until Friday.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.13 per cent lower at 99.97. PTI

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



The Housing & Urban Development Corporation Ltd (HUDCO) organised the 1st Regional Workshop on the Urban Invest Window (UiWIN) from 15–16 March 2026. Ponguru Narayana, Minister for Municipal Administration & Urban Development, Govt of Andhra Pradesh inaugurated the workshop. The event was also graced by Magunta Sreenivasulu Reddy, Member of Parliament from Ongole, Srinivas Katikithala, Secretary, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoUA); S Suresh Kumar, Principal Secretary, Municipal Administration & Urban Development, Govt of Andhra Pradesh and Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & MD, HUDCO.



A one-day Safety Training Programme was organised at Rail Coach Factory (RCF), Kapurthala in collaboration with the Directorate of Factories, Punjab, Chandigarh & the Punjab Industrial Safety Council, Chandigarh at the Technical Training Centre of RCF. Deputy Director of Factories, Kapurthala, Gurjant Singh, Jaspreet Singh & Joga Ram from Directorate of Factories Office were present on the occasion. Safety Officer Ashok Kumar Meghwal organised a quiz on occupational safety topics & prizes were distributed to the winning participants. Chief Safety Officer Jagmeet Singh delivered the vote of thanks at the conclusion of the programme.

PhonePe temporarily pauses IPO listing process

NEW DELHI: PhonePe on Monday announced it has temporarily deferred its public market listing process due to the current geopolitical conflicts and market volatility and will resume the listing process once there is some stability in global capital markets.

Sameer Nigam, PhonePe’s CEO said, “We sincerely hope for a swift return to peace in all the affected regions. We remain committed to a public listing in India.” PTI

Attorney General for India R Venkataramani calls for new framework for plea bargaining

NEW DELHI: Attorney General for India R Venkataramani on Monday called for a new national framework for plea bargaining based on social, cultural and economic principles to improve transparency and efficiency in the justice system.

Speaking at the seminar “Delivering Justice in Time: Global Practices and Indian Experiences,” organised by O P Jindal Global University and National Law University Delhi, Venkataramani said, “Plea bargaining is becoming universal. There is a need for a national protocol to guide practitioners and victims so the process works in a transparent and objective manner.” He also pro-



posed a National Institute for Criminal Justice Administration and a Legal Health Index. In his keynote Address, Dr. Abhishek M Singhvi, MP & Senior Advocate, Supreme Court of India highlighted India’s case backlog. “We must address the ‘ABCD’—access, backlog, cost and delay—by filling judicial vacancies, strength-

ening mediation, reviving Gram Nyayalayas and improving coordination among courts, police and prisons,” he said.

In his welcome address, C Raj Kumar, Founding Vice Chancellor, O P Jindal Global University said India faces over five crore pending cases and proposed five reform pillars including strengthening

judicial capacity, procedural reforms, technology and artificial intelligence in courts, expansion of plea bargaining and data-driven justice governance.

Prof. (Dr.) G S Bajpai, Vice Chancellor, National Law University Delhi said, “Speed alone does not equal justice,” stressing fairness, transparency and procedural integrity while calling for evaluation of timelines in new criminal laws and stronger victim justice frameworks.

A message from Minister of State for Law and Justice Arjun Ram Meghwal conveyed interest in the seminar’s outcomes. MPOST

IndiGo ties up with AAHL to offer BluChips on duty-free shopping

The partnership reflects a broader effort by both the companies to strengthen digital travel ecosystems

AHMEDABAD: IndiGo and Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL) have announced a strategic partnership enabling IndiGo BluChip members to earn on duty-free shopping across AAHL-managed airports.

Under the partnership, members can earn five IndiGo BluChips for every Rs 100 spent on duty-free products pre-booked through the Adani platform. Travellers can browse, reserve and pay for products online before departure and collect their purchases conveniently at the airport. Neetan Chopra, Chief Dig-



ital and Information Officer, IndiGo, said: “At IndiGo, we are continuously striving to enhance the value proposition of our loyalty program. This partnership with Adani Duty Free strengthens our commitment to offering meaningful rewards beyond flights, making

CLOSER LOOK

- » Travellers can browse, reserve & pay for products online before departure & collect their purchases at the airport
- » Customers can log in through a dedicated portal, link their IndiGo BluChip membership ID and receive their earnings within 24–48 hours

every step of the journey more beneficial for our customers. By combining IndiGo’s extensive network with Adani’s premium duty-free experience, we are delighted to bring greater convenience, choice, and value to millions of travelers across India.”

Suchit Bansal, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) – Non-Aero, AAHL, said: “We are transforming how travellers’ shop at airports by integrating digital discovery, pre-order convenience and seamless collection through the Adani platform. Our partnership with IndiGo

brings together India’s largest airline and the country’s largest private airport operator to deliver a more connected and rewarding travel retail experience.”

Customers can log in through a dedicated portal, link their IndiGo BluChip membership ID and receive their earnings within 24–48 hours of completing their purchase basis their spends.

The initiative aims to deliver a smoother travel experience by combining digital convenience, loyalty benefits and airport retail; elevating the travel experience. MPOST

Duty-free stores under the programme are currently available at airports in Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Thiruvananthapuram, Jaipur, Mangaluru and Lucknow, with expansion planned at Lokapriya Gopinath Bardoloi International Airport (LGBIA) in Guwahati and the newly operational Navi Mumbai International Airport (NMIA).

The partnership reflects a broader effort by both the companies to strengthen digital travel ecosystems, offering passengers a more integrated journey across booking, travel and airport services. MPOST

Exports dip to \$36.61 bn in Feb, trade deficit narrows to \$27.1 bn

The impact of West Asia crisis will be known in the data for month of March, as war began on Feb 28. The data will be released by mid-May

OUR CORRESPONDENT

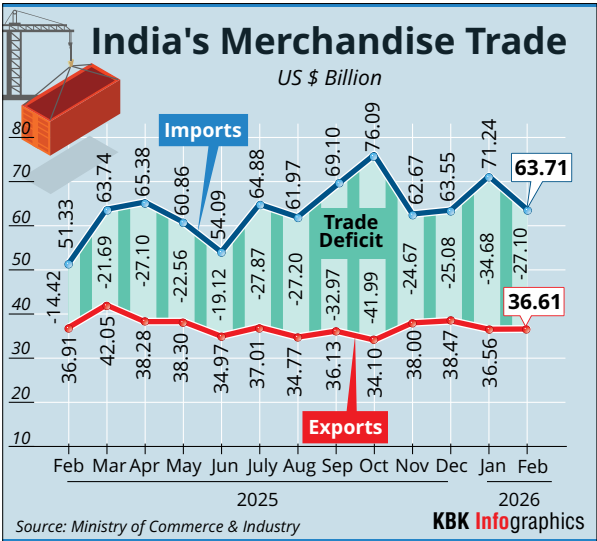
NEW DELHI: The country's merchandise exports dropped marginally by 0.81 per cent year-on-year to \$36.61 billion in February, and the trade deficit narrowed to \$27.1 billion compared to the previous month.

The impact of the West Asia crisis will be known in the data for the month of March, as the war began on February 28. The data will be released by mid-May.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal said exports in March will see a "southward" trend due to the logistical challenges amidst geopolitical tensions.

The joint attack launched by the US and Israel on Iran has disrupted the movement of consignments in international waters. It has led to a significant jump in oil prices, due to which air and ocean freight have risen sharply.

Imports in February increased by 24.11 per cent to \$63.71 billion due to a jump in gold and silver imports. Inbound shipments of gold rose 218.55 per cent to \$7.44 billion, while silver imports were up by 285.23 per cent to



\$1.66 billion.

India mainly imports the yellow metal from Switzerland, from where the inbound shipments have climbed 719.3 per cent to \$2.71 billion in February.

Oil imports were up 9 per cent to \$12.97 billion during the month.

The trade deficit has narrowed when compared to the previous month, when it was \$34.68 billion. However, the gap has widened year-on-year from \$14.05 billion recorded in

February 2025.

Briefing the media on the trade data, Agrawal said that the country's exports are doing well despite global economic challenges.

He said that the country's exports during the April-February period of FY26 went up 1.84 per cent to \$402.93 billion. Imports rose 8.53 per cent to \$713.53 billion during the period.

Merchandise trade deficit during the 11-month period of 2025-26 has increased to

Highlights

» Imports in Feb jumped by 24.11% to \$63.71 bn due to a jump in gold & silver imports

» Inbound shipments of gold rose 218.55 per cent to \$7.44 billion, while silver imports were up by 285.23 per cent to \$1.66 billion

» 'The country's exports during the April-Feb FY26 went up 1.84% to \$402.93 billion. Imports rose 8.53% to \$713.53 billion during the period'

\$310.60 billion as compared to \$261.80 billion in the same month last year.

When asked about India's imports from Russia, the secretary said: "We are buying Russian oil also...there has been an increased buying from Russian oil also, in the current month also, because of challenges we are facing."

At the exports front, key sectors such as petroleum, plastics, textiles, leather goods, iron ore, spices, cashew, oil meals, oil seeds, and tea

recorded negative growth in February.

However, shipments of rice, marine products, gems and jewellery, pharma, chemicals, engineering, and electronics have recorded positive growth.

As per the commerce ministry data, services exports are estimated at \$39.53 billion as compared to \$31.65 billion in January 2025. The imports are estimated at \$16.38 billion as compared to \$14.51 billion in the same month last year.

Commenting on the data, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) President S C Ralhan said the escalating conflict in the Middle East has heightened global trade uncertainty.

"Disruptions in key maritime routes, including the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea, have forced vessels to reroute, increasing freight costs, insurance premiums, and transit times, thereby adding pressure on exporters," he said.

He added that close monitoring of geopolitical developments, maintaining smooth logistics connectivity and providing timely policy support will be essential to sustain export momentum.

Top-10 wilful defaulters owe ₹40,635 crore to banks, says FM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Top-10 wilful defaulters including ABG Shipyard, Gitanjali Gems, and Housing Development and Infrastructure owe Rs 40,635 crore to banks as of March 31, 2025, Parliament was informed on Monday.

ABG Shipyard Ltd tops the list with Rs 6,695 crore due to banks followed by Gitanjali Gems Rs 6,236 crore, Beta Napthol Rs 5,268 crore and Rakesh-kumar Kuldipsingh Wadhawan Rs 4,291 crore, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said in a written reply to the Lok Sabha.

Besides, erstwhile directors of Bhushan Power & Steel Ltd owe Rs 3,810 crore, Raza Textiles Rs 3,260 crore, Gilt Pack Rs 3,080 crore, Rank Industries Rs 2,655 crore and Housing Development and Infrastructure Rs 2,540 crore to banks.

She further said, RBI, vide Master Directions on Treatment of wilful defaulters and large defaulters, has advised lenders to submit the list of wilful defaulters to all Credit Information Companies (CICs) on a monthly basis, and CICs are required to display the same on their respective websites.

As per inputs received from RBI, she said, a bank may undertake compromise settlements in respect of accounts categorized as wilful defaulters without prejudice to the criminal proceeding underway against such borrowers.

The primary regulatory objective behind allowing wilful defaulters to enter into com-



ABG Shipyard tops the list with Rs 6,695 cr, Gitanjali Gems Rs 6,236 crore, Beta Napthol Rs 5,268 crore, Rakesh-kumar Kuldipsingh Wadhawan Rs 4,291 crore

promise settlement is to enable multiple avenues to lenders to recover the money in default without much delay, she said.

Apart from the time value loss, inordinate delays result in asset value deterioration which hampers ultimate recoveries, she said, adding, compromise settlement is recognised as a valid resolution mechanism under RBI's (Commercial Banks – Resolution of Stressed Assets) Directions, 2025.

Further, she said, the imperatives for lenders are no different when it comes to recovery from borrowers classified as wilful defaulter. Continuing such exposures on the balance sheets of the lenders without resolution due to legal proceedings locks lenders' funds in an

unproductive asset, which is not a desirable position, she said.

Further, continuation of criminal proceedings underway or to be initiated against the borrowers classified as wilful defaulter ensures that perpetrators of any malafide action do not go scot-free.

Further, she said, compromise settlement is not available to borrowers as a matter of right; rather it is a discretion to be exercised by the lenders based on their commercial judgement.

Replying to another question, Sitharaman said, the digital payment transactions have grown exponentially in the last few years due to coordinated efforts of the government, RBI and National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI).

Retail digital payment has increased from Rs 457.44 lakh crore in FY22 to Rs 849.12 lakh crore in FY25, she said.

Of the total retail digital payment transactions, the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) accounted for 81 per cent in 2024-25 and has emerged as the largest real-time retail payment system in the world, she said.

"The specific data on demographic or geographic segments-wise contribution in digital payments is not maintained. The growth in retail digital payments, including UPI, is driven by several factors such as smartphone penetration, Aadhaar-enabled authentication, e-KYC, wider financial inclusion and expansion of merchant acceptance infrastructure across both urban and rural areas," she said.

Banks write off loans of ₹9.75 lakh cr in last 11 fiscals

NEW DELHI: Banks have written off loans worth Rs 9.75 lakh crore in the last 11 financial years, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said on Monday.

The write off peaked in FY20 at Rs 1.59 lakh crore, and since then it has been declining to Rs 47,568 crore in FY25.

Banks have written off Rs 31,723 crore in FY15, Rs 40,416 crore in FY16, Rs 68,308 crore in FY 17, and Rs 99,132 crore in FY18, he said in a written reply to the Lok Sabha.

In 2018-19, he said, the write off of loans crossed Rs 1 lakh crore to Rs 1.59 lakh crore.

"Banks write off NPAs, including those in respect of which full provisioning has been made on completion of four years, as per RBI guidelines and policy approved by banks' boards. Such a write-off does not result in waiver of liabilities of borrowers, and therefore, it does not benefit the borrower," he said.

The borrowers continue to be liable for repayment, and banks continue to pursue recovery actions initiated in these accounts, he added.

The recovery in written-off loans is an ongoing process, and banks continue pursuing their recovery actions initiated against borrowers under various recovery mechanisms available to them, the minister noted.

India's exports to US fall 13% in Feb

NEW DELHI: India's exports to the US dipped 12.88 per cent year-on-year to \$6.88 billion in February due to high tariffs in America, while the trade deficit with China crossed \$100 billion during the 11-month period of this fiscal, according to the commerce ministry data released on Monday.

Exports contracted in September, October, December last year and January this year also. However, it rose 22.61 per cent in November.

Indian goods were attracting a sweeping 50 per cent levies in the US.

But after US Supreme Court struck down the Trump tariffs, US President Donald Trump imposed 10 per cent duty on all countries from February 24 for 150 days.

So now the impact of the lower tariffs is likely to be reflected in the data for the month of March, which will



be released in mid-May.

Imports, on the other hand, from the US grew 36.53 per cent to \$4.48 billion in February, data showed.

During the April-February period of this fiscal year, the country's exports to the US increased 3.84 per cent to \$79.29 billion, while imports rose 15.65 per cent to \$48.4 billion.

The country's exports to China rose 32.37 per cent to \$1.67 billion, while imports surged 30.49 per cent to \$11.95 billion.

During the 11-month period of this fiscal year, the country's exports to China increased

37.66 per cent to \$17.54 billion, while imports rose 15.21 per cent to \$119.55 billion. Trade deficit has reached \$102.01 billion.

India's exports to Germany, Hong Kong, Italy, Nepal, France, Brazil, Spain, Belgium, Malaysia and Vietnam saw growth during the month under review.

However, exports to the UK, the Netherlands, the UK, Saudi Arabia, Bangladesh, Singapore, Australia, and South Africa contracted.

On the imports front, shipments in February declined from the UAE, Russia, Germany, Thailand and Qatar.

However, imports rose from Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Switzerland, Singapore, Hong Kong, Japan, Korea and Indonesia.

India mainly imports gold from Switzerland. The country's imports from this nation zoomed about 7 times in February to \$2.71 billion.

RIL signs \$3 bn deal to supply green ammonia to South Korea's Samsung C&T for 15 years

NEW DELHI: Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) has signed a \$3 billion deal to supply green ammonia to South Korea's Samsung C&T for 15 years, the firm said on Monday.

The agreement, one of the largest long-term green ammonia deals globally, positions India as an emerging exporter of green fuels produced through a fully indigenous value chain, including domestic manufacturing of critical clean-energy equipment. The supply is set to commence in the second half of fiscal 2029.

In a statement, Reliance said it "has entered into a binding long-term supply and purchase agreement (SPA) with Samsung C&T Corporation, South Korea,

for the supply of Green Ammonia over a 15-year period commencing in the second half of FY2029.

"The SPA, valued at more than \$3 billion, is one of the largest binding long-term green ammonia off-take agreements globally," it said.

Green ammonia is produced using renewable energy sources instead of fossil fuels, making it a carbon-free or low-carbon alternative. Unlike conventional ammonia, which is made using natural gas, green ammonia is produced by combining hydrogen from green hydrogen (obtained via electrolysis of water using renewable electricity) with nitrogen from the air.

It can be used as a fertiliser, industrial chemical, or fuel for power generation and shipping.

Reliance is developing a fully integrated new energy platform encompassing renewable energy, energy storage, green hydrogen, and downstream green fuels and chemicals, supported by in-house manufacturing of solar modules, battery energy storage systems (BESS), and electrolyser systems.

The initiative aligns with India's National Green Hydrogen Mission and the government's push for self-reliance in critical clean-energy technologies.

"A central pillar of the company's new energy ecosystem is the indigenisation of criti-

cal clean energy technologies in India, including Solar modules, Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS), and Electrolyser systems, in line with the Government of India's vision for self-reliance and domestic manufacturing leadership," the statement said.

"By integrating these capabilities within a single ecosystem, RIL aims to deliver green energy solutions that are competitive, scalable, and reliable for global markets while strengthening India's industrial base."

The agreement with Samsung C&T is the first in a series of long-term offtake partnerships supporting the scale-up of RIL's New Energy platform.

NEW DELHI: The government has eased localisation requirements under the Phased Manufacturing Programme (PMP) of the Rs 10,900 crore PM E-DRIVE Scheme, providing major relief to manufacturers of electric trucks and buses by allowing them to import traction motors with rare-earth magnets till August 31.

In separate notifications dated March 13, the Ministry of Heavy Industries deferred the deadline to stop imports of traction motors used in e-trucks (N2/N3) and e-buses (M2/M3), a decision expected to ease component shortages faced by manufacturers.

The deadline for local manufacturing of traction motors used in e-bus and e-truck categories has been extended for the second time, as in September last year, the Centre deferred it till March 2026.

The requirement under Phased Manufacturing Programme (PMP) of the PM Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement (PM E-DRIVE) Scheme stipulates that the "manufacturing of traction motor which at least includes magnet fitment, fitment of rotor assembly into motor, fitment of stator assembly into motor, shaft fitment, bearing fitment, enclosure fit-

ment, connectors fitment, cables fitment shall be domestically performed". It has now been amended to be in effect from September 1, 2026.

While the government is taking measures to reduce the import dependence on China for rare earth magnets, as these are critical inputs in order to secure supply chains for EVs, electronics, aerospace and green energy, securing a steady supply chain has been a challenge until now. The Centre has notified the Scheme to Promote Manufacturing of Sintered Rare Earth Permanent Magnet (REPM) with an outlay of Rs 7,280 crore.

Nita M Ambani Conferred prestigious KISS Humanitarian Award 2025

Award was presented by Nobel Laureate from Sri Lanka Prof. Mohan Munasinghe in presence of the Founder of KIIT, KISS & KIMS Dr Achyuta Samanta

BHUBANESWAR: Nita M Ambani, Founder and Chairperson of Reliance Foundation, was conferred the prestigious KISS Humanitarian Award 2025 at Kalinga Institute of Social Sciences (KISS) campus here on Monday.

The award was presented by Nobel Laureate from Sri Lanka Prof. Mohan Munasinghe in the presence of the Founder of KIIT, KISS and KIMS Dr Achyuta Samanta. Senior functionaries of the institutions and a large number of students and dignitaries attended the function.

The award recognised Ambani's outstanding humanitarian initiatives and her significant contributions to social development through education, healthcare, rural transformation, women empowerment and sports promotion through the Reliance Foundation.

In her acceptance speech, Ambani said that Dr. Samanta has built two modern temples of education — KIIT and KISS. These two institutions are a matter of pride for our country. She said that she feels proud to receive the prestigious KISS Humanitarian Award

and added that the honour is not hers alone, but belongs to the entire team of Reliance Foundation.

Addressing the 40,000 students of KISS, she said, "I will never forget the love and affection you have given me here." She further said that it was truly a privilege for her to visit the two remarkable institutions, KIIT and KISS.

She expressed that she was overwhelmed to come to the pious land of Lord Jagannath. She also added that Odisha has a rich culture, traditions and values, and that the people of



Odisha share a deep and strong connection with nature

She said that there is no difference between boys and girls

and that whatever boys can do, girls can do as well. Advising the students, she said, "This is just the beginning, not your

final goal. You should dream big, and to achieve those dreams, you must work hard with dedication."

She further advised the students never to leave the path of righteousness. "I see the future of India here in KISS. After seeing the children here, I am confident that the future of India is bright," she added.

The KISS Humanitarian Award, initiated in 2008 by Dr Samanta, is the highest honour of KISS, dedicated to recognising individuals and organisations that embody the spirit of humanitarian work worldwide.

The award consists of a citation scroll and a gold-plated trophy.

The trophy symbolises the golden heart of a humanitarian representing the virtues of purity, kindness, prosperity and hope.

It features a pair of hands uplifting a heart textured with shapes resembling waving hands, signifying how dedicated efforts can transform the lives of the underprivileged and make the world a better place.

In his welcome speech Dr. Samanta said, Success doesn't mean achieving things only for yourself; true success is bring-

ing light into the lives of others." Giving example of Nita Ambani he said, Great initiatives never go in vain if you try with dedication. He praised Nita for her multi-dimensional social work, for which she is loved and respected by one and all. In this materialistic world, earning love and respect is not easy. However, Mrs. Ambani has earned immense love and respect from people for her noble social and humanitarian work. He thanked Mrs. Ambani for graciously accepting the KISS Humanitarian Award.

MP0ST

Next Stop: Dhoni school

After T20 WC exploits, Samson looking to learn from Dhoni at CSK

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: India's T20 World Cup-winning hero Sanju Samson said on Monday that he is keen to pick up a few lessons from the legendary "Captain Cool" MS Dhoni when he links up with the former India skipper at Chennai Super Kings in the upcoming edition of the Indian Premier League.

Having spent a majority of his IPL career at Rajasthan Royals, the India wicketkeeper-batter will turn out in CSK colours when the two teams face off in their tournament opener in Guwahati on March 30.

"I have spoken to Mahi bhai (Dhoni) over the phone and interacted with him, but playing with him as part of a team will be great. I see it as an opportunity to learn from him," Samson told reporters.

While it would technically be a home game for Rajasthan Royals, the IPL champions in 2008, Samson said that being in the opposition camp would bring a different set of emotions, though the 31-year-old insisted he would not allow sentiment to dictate his approach on the field.

"(I am) looking forward to playing for CSK, I feel grateful for the love and attention I have been getting from fans," he said. "This is the first time I will



Sanju Samson said he won't hold back against former team Rajasthan Royals

BCCI

play against Rajasthan Royals, but I don't let emotions rule me on the field. I left Rajasthan Royals because I felt my time in the team was over. Even if we come up against them now, I will play my best cricket," Samson added.

Samson said he spent time introspecting after an ordinary run before the T20 World Cup but termed the experience of winning the trophy as a "spiritual moment". "I wasn't very confident when I left home to play in the World Cup, but

the universe had other plans; I played well and the reception has been great," said Samson, who was adjudged the Player of the Tournament in World Cup. "It was a private, spiritual moment. When I go out on the field, I carry the dreams of thousands with me; they want to see me perform well to know that a small-town boy can play on the biggest stage in cricket," said Samson.

Samson struck scores of 89, 97 not out and 89 in the last three matches to power India to

their third T20 World Cup title. Among those three knocks, he termed the unbeaten 97 against the West Indies in the virtual knockout game in the Super Eights as the "most important". "After the New Zealand series, I did a lot of introspection and rebuilt my mindset; I realised that I had the talent. (The knock of) 97 against West Indies was the most important knock in my opinion as I had to keep my cool even as wickets fell on the other end," Samson said. AGENCIES

Would love to play Test: Suryakumar

NEW DELHI: World Cup-winning skipper Suryakumar Yadav says he yearns to play Test cricket, finds ODI not his cup of tea, but ultimately his forte is T20 because "usmey apna haath set ho gaya hai". In an exclusive podcast interview with PTI, Suryakumar occasionally slipped into charming Mumbaii Hindi, such as the "haath set ho gaya hai" phrase which has no decent English equivalent. Roughly translated, he meant to say he is now a master of the shortest format of cricket and is comfortable playing that. "T20 mein jaisa chal raha tha, usme apna haath set ho gaya hai, aisa bol sakte hain" (The way T20 was working out for me, I had become good at it; you can say that), he said.

Given an opportunity, would he want to play Tests? Without hesitation he replied: "I would love to." AGENCIES

GETS KARNATAKA GOVT NOD

Chinnaswamy Stadium cleared to host IPL games, and final

S KANNAN

NEW DELHI: In what will come as music to the ears of Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) fans, the Karnataka State Government on Monday formally granted approval for the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium to host matches during the 2026 edition of the Indian Premier League (IPL).

The action in Bengaluru will begin with a blockbuster clash on March 28, when defending champions RCB take on Sunrisers Hyderabad. The city is also set to host one playoff match and the IPL final, although details are yet to be finalised.

The clearance comes after months of uncertainty surrounding the stadium following the tragic stampede on June 4 during RCB's victory celebrations, which led to the death of 11 people and more than 50 were injured.

The incident triggered widespread outrage and raised serious questions about crowd management and safety. Despite RCB issuing an apology and providing compensation, doubts lingered over whether Bengaluru would be allowed to host IPL matches this season.

Last week, a committee



Top-flight cricket is back at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium

AP

It will also jostle the tournament's opening ceremony

appointed by Karnataka Home Minister G. Parameshwara conducted an extensive review of the stadium. The inspection lasted over 12 hours and covered crowd-control mechanisms, infrastructure, and overall safety preparedness, according to sources in the Karnataka State Cricket Association (KSCA).

At one stage, about two months ago, RCB had even considered shifting their matches out of Bengaluru due to the stringent safety conditions being proposed by the

state government.

However, efforts by the KSCA leadership helped revive the possibility of cricket returning to the city. Since former India fast bowler Venkatesh Prasad took over as KSCA president after winning the association's elections in December 2025, he and his team have held multiple meetings with RCB officials and the state government.

Prasad had strongly urged RCB to continue playing their home matches in Bengaluru, stressing that the city and its fans were central to the franchise's identity and its maiden IPL triumph last year. Virat Kohli remains a marquee figure for the franchise and a huge draw for local supporters.

ORLEANS MASTERS

Ayush, Tanvi to carry Indian hopes in France



Ayush Shetty will look to make a deep run

FILE

ORLEANS: Youngsters Ayush Shetty and Tanvi Sharma will lead India's challenge at the \$250,000 Orleans Masters Super 300 beginning here on Tuesday after senior shuttler HS Prannoy pulled out due to a shoulder injury.

Prannoy, who was originally slated to face top seed Chou Tien Chen of Chinese Taipei in the opening round, was forced to withdraw after experiencing shoulder pain during the Swiss Open in Basel last week.

While the cause of his discomfort was unclear initially, the Indian had decided to pull out of his match against Japan's Koki Watanabe to avoid aggravating the injury.

"The shoulder pain developed after travelling to the Swiss Open. We didn't know the reason then, so I decided to withdraw," Prannoy said. "After a scan it showed a slight tear. It is a minor thing and hopefully I should be okay soon," added the seasoned pro, who is targeting a return at the Asian Championships to be held from April 7 to 12 in Ningbo, China.

While Prannoy will miss the event, the rest of the Indian contingent will look to make a deep run in the tournament.

All eyes will be on eighth

“The shoulder pain developed after travelling to the Swiss Open. We didn't know the reason then, so I decided to withdraw”
HS Prannoy

seed and world No. 25 Ayush Shetty, who won the US Open Super 300 last year, as he opens his campaign against Lee Chia Hao of Chinese Taipei.

Former world No. 1 and currently ranked 30th, Kidambi Srikanth, who reached the finals of the Malaysia Masters Super 500 and Syed Modi International Super 300 in 2025, will face Denmark's Magnus Johanesen. Tharun Manneppalli, fresh from a quarterfinal finish at last week's Swiss Open, takes on Chinese Taipei's Wang Tzu Wei in his opening game.

World No. 42 Kiran George, who stunned Singapore's former world champion Loh Kean Yew at the Swiss Open, will face third seed Kenta Nishimoto of Japan. AGENCIES

Sooryavanshi terms U-19 WC final knock 'special'

JAIPUR: India's teenage cricket sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi on Monday described his match-defining century against England in the Under-19 World Cup final as one of the most "special" knocks of his budding career, a memorable innings that played a decisive role in India lifting the title.

Sooryavanshi smashed a stunning 175 off just 80 balls to power India to a record-extending sixth U-19 World Cup title. "My personal favourite is the final knock in the U-19 World Cup (in Harare). I could only play one U-19 World Cup. It was a proud moment for me to score a hundred in the final," he said. "What I contributed for the team in the final was special," he said on the sidelines of an event to unveil the new jersey of Rajasthan Royals and announce its partnership with JK Lakshmi Cement.

Asked about his goal in this year's IPL, Sooryavanshi said he is just focusing on his process and not thinking about other things. "I try to focus on winning. I just focus on my work." AGENCIES

AFC says Iran set to play at World Cup

KUALA LUMPUR: A leading soccer official in Asia says Iran is still set to play at the World Cup which kicks off in June in the United States, Canada and Mexico.

In a social media post last week in reaction to comments from US President Donald Trump, Iran's national team said "no one can exclude" it from playing in the tournament. On Monday, Asian Football Confederation general secretary Windsor John said the sport's continental governing body has heard nothing to suggest Iran won't contest the World Cup.

"They are our member. We want them to

play," he told a news conference in Kuala Lumpur, where the AFC is based. "As far as we know, Iran is playing."

"It's a very emotional moment, everybody is saying a lot of things. At the end of the day, it's the (Iran soccer) federation who should decide if they're playing and, as for today, the federation ... has told us that they're going to the World Cup." Trump had posted on social media that the Iranian team was welcome at the World Cup despite the ongoing war with Iran but that "I really don't believe it is appropriate that they be there, for their own life and safety." AGENCIES

On Tuesday, Manchester City will start 3-0 down at home to Real Madrid and Chelsea faces a 5-2 deficit

Tottenham trails 5-2 at home to Atletico Madrid on Wednesday, when Liverpool will hope the aura of its Anfield home can help overcome a 1-0 loss in the first leg at Galatasaray. Newcastle goes to Barcelona tied at 1-1. In the two games without an English team, the remarkable Norwe-

gian underdogs Bodo/Glimt take a 3-0 lead to Sporting Lisbon on Tuesday and Bayern Munich is up 6-1 hosting Atalanta on Wednesday.

Bodo/Glimt's big stage Bodo/Glimt should have no fear going to Sporting's 52,000-seat Jose Alvalade Stadium that is more than six times bigger than its stadium.

Coach Kjetil Knutsen's team already won this year in front of bigger crowds and intense atmospheres at Atletico's Metropolitan Stadium and the San Siro against Inter Milan. Glimt's shocking 2-1 win at Atletico in the last round of league-phase games in January meant squeezing into the 24-team knockout phase placed 23rd in the 36-team standings. A 2-1 win in Milan completed a 5-2 scoreline in the knockout play-offs round in February. AGENCIES



Federico Valverde's historic treble vs Man City was one for the ages

AP

the winter, lambs by the spring," Platini said while UEFA president from 2007-15, quoting a phrase that seems to have come from the former Yugoslavia decades ago.

On Tuesday, Manchester City will start 3-0 down at home to Real Madrid and Chelsea faces a 5-2 deficit against defending champion Paris Saint-Germain.



Aryna Sabalenka beat Elena Rybakina in the final

AP

10
This is Sabalenka's 10th WTA 1000 title -- and her sixth different event

It was a sweltering afternoon on the court as the temperatures soared into the 90s. The 27-year-old Sabalenka had a chance to close out the third set but was broken at 5-4. Rybakina found herself with a championship point in the tie-

breaker, only to have Sabalenka hit a backhand winner.

"I think the whole idea going into this match was to be mentally strong, to stay strong, no matter what, to show with the body language that I'm here, I'm fighting," Sabalenka said in a post-match interview on the Tennis Channel. "You have to get a win with incredible tennis and that was the whole idea going into this one. I'm happy that it really worked."

It's been quite a stretch for Sabalenka. First, a puppy and then an engagement ring from Brazilian businessman Georgios Frangulis.

Now, a title in the desert. "I'll remember it for the rest of my life," she said. AGENCIES

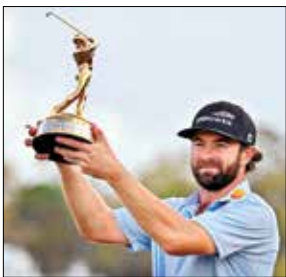
Young comes if age, rallies to win The Players Championship

PONTE VERDA BEACH: Cameron Young delivered the biggest birdie of his career on the most notorious hole on the TPC Sawgrass, a sand wedge to 10 feet to tie for the lead in The Players Championship. And then he was even better on a shot equally daunting.

Young finally won a big title to go with his major talent on an electric stage with pressure at every turn. He produced the goods on the final two holes — the birdie on the wind-blown island-green 17th, and a 375-yard drive down the 18th that set up a one-shot victory Sunday. "It's so loud on 17. You just know kind of all eyes are right there on you so there's nowhere to hide," Young said. "And I feel like I stepped up really well and hit a bunch of good shots those last couple holes, so I'm very proud of that."

Most impressive was the previous day on the 18th hole, his drive ended with a splash and a double bogey. There was no margin for error this time, tied for the lead with Matt Fitzpatrick. Young picked out his line and had one final thought: "I'm going to hit the best shot of my life right here."

He had never had a thought like that because he had never been in this position before.



Cameron Young with the trophy

AP

But he couldn't think of a better shot he ever hit. Moments later, Fitzpatrick failed to save par from the trees when he missed an 8-foot putt.

Young tapped in for par and a 4-under 68. "The nerves kicked in over the 8-inch putt on the last," Young said. "That hole looked really, really small there from pretty close range."

It was only his second victory on the PGA Tour. He tied the tour record with seven runner-up finishes before finally winning late last summer in the Wyndham Championship. But this is the PGA Tour's crown jewel, loosely known as the fifth major, on a Stadium Course that taxes brains and more than not breaks hearts. It was like that for Ludvig Aberg, who had a three-shot lead going into the final round and was still in control until he imploded. AGENCIES

Laporta wins 5 more years as Barca's prez

BARCELONA: Joan Laporta was reelected as the president of FC Barcelona for another five years after winning a leadership vote among members of the Spanish soccer powerhouse.

Shortly after midnight in Barcelona, the club announced Laporta had won. His only rival, Victor Font, had earlier conceded defeat and congratulated Laporta "for his unquestionable victory."

With the counting now over, Barcelona said Laporta received 68% of the votes.

The club said that more than 48,000 of Barça's 114,000 club members cast ballots at Camp Nou Stadium or at four other voting stations across Catalonia in northeastern Spain and in Andorra. "Thanks to this marvelous club, where its fans still vote to decide who will be their president and executive board," Laporta said in his victory speech inside an auditorium at Camp Nou, flanked by members of his incoming board. Laporta successfully presided over Barça from 2003-10 during the glory years of coach Pep Guardiola and a young Lionel Messi. He was voted back into his post in 2021 when the club was in a dire economic situation after the lavish spending on players by Josep Bartomeu. AGENCIES

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
SUBERNAREKHA CANAL DIVISION, JAMSHEDPUR
(Email ID:- eesdcjsr.chandil@gmail.com)

E-Procurement Tender Notice (e-Tender Notice)
E-Tender Ref. No.: WRD/SCD/JSR/SBD-02/2025-26 DATE- 16.03.2026

1.	Name of Work	Strengthening of lining work, Structures, Embankment and Jungle Clearance of Chandil Left Main Canal from KM. 32.238 to Km. 59.720 .
2.	Estimated cost of work (in INR)	Rs. 13,18,33,202.55 (Rupees thirteen crore eighteen lakhs thirty three thousand two hundred two rupees and fifty five paise only)
3.	Initial Bid Security (in INR)	Rs.13,19,000/- (Rupees thirteen lakh nineteen thousand only)
4.	Initial Bid Security	Initial Bid Security online deposit - As per SOP issued by Information Technology and E-Governance Department, Govt. of Jharkhand. Vide letter no-120 dated-03.10.2023
5.	Cost of Bidding Documents	Rs. 10,000.00 (Rupees ten thousand only) Online Deposit
6.	Time of completion	360 days
7.	Date of Publication of Tender on Website	23.03.2026 (4:30 P.M.)
8.	Start Date of Bidding	23.03.2026 (4:30 P.M.)
9.	Last Date and time for online Bidding	13.04.2026 up to 5.00 P.M
10.	Type of Bid	Two Envelope Mode (Technical & Financial Bid)
11.	Last Date & Time for receipt of Bid Security and other Documents in online form	13.04.2026 (5.00 PM) Through e-Tendering Portal www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in - As per SOP issued by Information Technology and E-Governance Department, Govt. of Jharkhand. Vide letter no-120 dated-03.10.2023
12.	Date & Time for opening of Technical Bid	15.04.2026 at 12.00 PM by E-procurement cell office of the Chief Engineer, Swarnrekha Project chandil complex Adityapur, Jamshedpur
13.	Name & Address of office inviting Tender	Executive Engineer,Subernarekha Canal Division, Jamshedpur
14.	Contact no. of Procurement officer	7903560727
15.	Helpline no. of E-Procurement Cell	0657-2371765

Above informations are only indicative. Detail NIT and SBD Published on Tender Portal shall be final and mandatory. Details can be seen on Website <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>

Executive Engineer
Subernarekha Canal Division,
Jamshedpur.

PR 375248 Water
Resource(25-26)#D

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Birender Kumar, S/o: Ghana Ram, R/o: F-456, Ganga Vihar, Gokal Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 351/19, U/s: 129/55 Gambling Act, Police Station Gokal Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Birender Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Birender Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Birender Kumar of Police Station Gokal Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **15.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shruti Saraswat
JMFC-03, North East, Room No. 22,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/3297/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Deepak, S/o: Nathu Lal, R/o: H.No. 3242, Mahindra Park, Rani Bagh, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 504/2017 U/s 354/354 D/506 IPC, P.S.: Subhash Place, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Deepak** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Deepak** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Deepak** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 504/2017 U/s 354/354 D/506 IPC, P.S.: Subhash Place, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Aishwarya Sharma
Judicial Magistrate First Class, (Mahila Court)-01
Room No. 106
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/3330/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

Name change

I, Roma Bhardwaj W/o Raaj Kumar R/o 642, Block -B, Sainik Colony, Sector -49, Faridabad, declare that Roma Bhardwaj, Roma Sharma, Seema Sharma and Seema Bhardwaj all names are one and same person

COURT NOTICE
(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)
IN THE COURT OF
Ms. Meenakshi Yadav
Civil Judge,(Senior Division)
Charkhi Dadri
Rohit
Vs.
General Public
CNR No. HRCDO2-000428-2023
Next Date:-17-04-2026
PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
General Public
The petitioner has filed Succession Petition for issuing succession certificate in lieu of and for the estate of late Jai Singh son of Sh. Balwant, resident of Village Ghosola, District Charkhi Dadri in respect of amount lying deposited in the respondent no 2 in the names of aforesaid person account no 80230100146425, any one having objection should appear in person or through counsel on 17.04.2026 at 10 a.m.
1. Rohit Chahar S/o Jai Singh, resident of Village Ghosola, Tehsil and Distt. Charkhi Dadri

Petitioner

Vs

1.General Public
2. Sarva Haryana Gramin Bank, Charkhi Dadri, through its Branch Manager.

Defendants

For details logon to <https://highcourtchd.gov.in>/Trs = district notice & distdri = Bhiwani
Sd/-Ms. Meenakshi Yadav
Civil Judge,(Senior Division)
Dated 13.03-2026 Charkhi Dadri

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Pradeep @ Bholu, S/o: Deep Chand, R/o: Village Pamala, Balmiki Mohalla, Bahadurgarh, Haryana** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 39084/2024 U/s 317(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Mundka, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Pradeep @ Bholu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Pradeep @ Bholu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Pradeep @ Bholu** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 39084/2024 U/s 317(2) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Mundka, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.04.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Gaurav Singal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06 (West)
Room No. 355, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/3337/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ravi Vaid @ Ravi Phalwan, S/o: Kishan Kumar, R/o: 771/12, RR-Block, Naveen Shahdara, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 354/2015, U/s: 307/182/203/120B/34 IPC, 25A.ACT, P.S. Shahdara, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Ravi Vaid @ Ravi Phalwan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Ravi Vaid @ Ravi Phalwan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ravi Vaid @ Ravi Phalwan of P.S. Shahdara, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Mohit Sharma
CJM, 3rd Floor, Shahdara Distt., Room No. 59,
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/3233/SHD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C / 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Ashlesh Gupta, S/o.: Late Sh. Hari Shankar Gupta, R/o.: H. No. 54, 3rd Floor, Pushpanjali Enclave, Karkardooma, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **FIR No.219/2019 dated 11.11.2019, U/S 420/406/409/468/471/120B IPC** registered at P.S EOW, Delhi and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said **Ashlesh Gupta** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Ashlesh Gupta** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ashlesh Gupta**, accused of **FIR No. 219/2019 dated 11.11.2019, U/S 420/406/409/468/471/120B IPC, P.S EOW, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.04.2026**.

By Order, Sh. Midul Gupta
Chief Judicial Magistrate,
New Delhi District, 26,
Ground Floor, Annex Building,
Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

DP/3383/EOW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sunny S/o Anoop R/o E-153, Vijay Vihar, Phase-2, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 7515/2018 U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. North Rohini, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sunny** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sunny** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sunny** of case **FIR No. 7515/2018 U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. North Rohini, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **26.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Ebbani Aggarwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
North West, Court No. 107, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3254/RD/2026 (Court Matter)

Advertisement No 02/2026
CENTRAL SANSKRIT UNIVERSITY
Established by an Act of Parliament
56-57, Institutional Area, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058
Website: www.sanskrit.nic.in

RECRUITMENT NOTIFICATION

The Central Sanskrit University, Delhi invites applications from Indian Nationals for recruitment to various Non-Teaching Posts [Registrar-01, Assistant Registrar-02, System Analyst-03, Section Officer-11, Nursing Officer-03, Assistant-10, Guest House Manager-03, Junior Engineer-03, Personal Assistant-03, Professional Assistant-04, Technical Assistant (Shikshashastra/Education Lab.)-03, Technical Assistant (Computer Lab.)-04, Stenographer-08, Upper Division Clerk-16, Library Assistant-01, Lower Division Clerk-35, Driver-01, Multi-Tasking Staff-22, Library Attendant-08 & Medical Attendant/Dresser-03]. Detailed information regarding eligibility criteria, qualifications, age limit, recruitment process, distribution of vacancies, application procedure, scheme of examination, selection process and other essential requirements will be available in the detailed advertisement no. 02/2026, available on 16.03.2026 at CSU's website www.sanskrit.nic.in under recruitment/notification head. All interested candidates are strictly advised to go through the detailed advertisement before filing the application.

Sd/-
REGISTRAR I/c

Date: 16.03.2026 CBC 21212/12/0007/2526

ICICI Bank
Branch office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.
Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Ravi Kumar/ R Insprio It Private Limited/ Yagendra Prasad/ Anita Kumari/ Paritosh Pandey/ LBNOD00005185390	Unit Bearing No 1705, 17th Floor Tower/ Block 15 Along With Single Bay Double Covered Car Parking (1+1) Silt Exotica Dreamville, Built on Plot No Gh-01A, Sector 16 C Greater Noida- 201307/ March 11, 2026	November 19, 2025 Rs.7,18,513/-	Delhi NCR/ Rohtas Bihar
2.	Manoj Kumar/ Anshul Sharma/ LBGH200004861411	Flat/ Unit Bearing No B-607 7th Floor, Tower B, Ajnara Homes Built on Plot No Gh-03 Sector 16 B, Gautam Budh Nagar (With 1 Open Car Parking Space) Greater Noida 201307/ March 11, 2026	September 18, 2025 Rs. 14,92,783.32/-	Delhi NCR
3.	Manish Kumar/ Roma Raj/ LBNOD00006345312/ LBNOD00006345326/ LBNOD00005701776	Flat No D-1801 17th Floor Ratan Pearls Situated At Gh-01D, Sector 16 Greater Noida West- 201307/ March 11, 2026	November 24, 2025 Rs.23,50,836/-	Delhi NCR/ Gaya Bihar

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: March 17, 2026
Place: Delhi/ NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

தமிழ்நாடு மத்திய பல்கலைக்கழகம்
தமிழ்நாடு மத்திய பல்கலைக்கழகம்
Central University of Tamil Nadu
(Established by an Act of Parliament, 2009)
Neelakudi, Thiruvaur Tamil Nadu

தென்டர் குறிப்பீடு / निविदा सूचना / Tender Notice
1. Wall panelling, wooden flooring works and false ceiling, etc. in Swayam Production centre, Library first floor, Academic Campus, Central University of Tamil Nadu (CUTN), Thiruvaur
2. Upgradation of the existing 100 KLD Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) to MBBR Technology, including supply, installation, testing and commissioning of electromechanical equipment, along with operation and maintenance for a period of one year, CUTN, Thiruvaur.
3. Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Split Type Air Conditioners for Pulse Laboratory, CUTN, Thiruvaur.

தென்டர் குறிப்பீடு எண் / निविदा संदर्भ सं./ Tender Ref. No.:
1. CUTN/ENGG/CVL/Tender/2025/26/27
2. CUTN/ENGG/ELE/Tender/2025/26/73
3. CUTN/ENGG/ELI C/Tender/2025/26/04

இறுதி தேதி & நேரம் / अंतिम तिथि एवं समय / Last date & Time:
Please see the CUTN website <https://cutn.ac.in/tenders>

குறிப்பு / टिप्पणी / Note: **தொழில் விவரங்களுக்கு CUTN இணையதளம்**
மற்றும் CPP போர்ட் க் பார்க்கவும்.
अधिक जानकारी के लिए कृपया तस्के की वेबसाइट www.cutn.ac.in और सोपीपी पोर्टल देखें।
For more details, please see the CUTN website www.cutn.ac.in and CPP portal.

செயலாட்சி இயக்குமதி/REGISTRAR
CBC 21299/12/0022/2526

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Tender Notice No.- JHS-N-GSU-06-26 Date- 09.03.2026

E-TENDERING NOTICE

Dy. Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer/GSU/Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi, for and on behalf of President of India invite open Tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following works.

E-Tender Notice No.: JHS-N-GSU-06-26

Description of work: EI alteration and other S&T work in connection with Provision of shunting neck connected with UP Loop line at Bijauli & Khajraha Station of Jhansi Division.

Approx. Cost	Earnest Money	Cost of Tender Form
₹ 11499885.93	₹ 207500.00	Nil

Opening of Tender : 02.04.2026 Time 15.00
Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance: 12 Months

* Tender on line can be submitted upto 15.00 hrs on 02.04.2026 * For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in (JHANSI DIVISION-GATI SHAKTI, NORTH CENTRALRLY) 594/26 FA

North central railways @CPRONCR www.nor.indianrailways.gov.in

UJVNL LTD.
H.O.: 'UJJWAL', Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax 0135-2763508
CIN No.: U40101UR2001SGC025868, Website : www.ujvnl.com

Tender Notice Dated 16.03.2026
Office of the Executive Engineer (M&G) Kulhal Power Station, Kulhal, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Tender No. 13/UJVNL/EE(M&G)/KPS/2025-26: "Dismantling of overhead 33kV medium voltage covered conductor (MVCC) and laying of 33 kV XLPE underground cable."
Tender No. 14/UJVNL/EE(M&G)/KPS/2025-26: Procurement of different types of Canon make printer cartridge for various offices of Kulhal Power Station.
Tender No. 15/UJVNL/EE(M&G)/KPS/2025-26: Procurement of toner cartridge for Sharp DX 2000U Photocopy machine located at Kulhal Power House.
Estimated cost: Rs. 9.52,348/-, Rs. 1.32,380/- & Rs. 69,605/- GST Extra respectively
Date of availability of bid document on website : 18/03/2026 11:00 Hrs
Last date for submission of tender: 08/04/2026 15:00 Hrs
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvnl.com"
Executive Engineer (M&G) Kulhal

"Avoid Wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shakil S/o Mustkeem R/o House No. E-219, Gali No. 4, West Vinod Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 944/2014 U/s 354/341/354(D)/506 IPC, PS Mandwali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Shakil** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Shakil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shakil of FIR No. 944/2014 U/s 354/341/354(D)/506 IPC, PS Mandwali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **17.04.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Ritika Kansal
Judicial Magistrate First Class
(Mahila Court-02), Court No. 24
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/3373/ED/2026(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Open Tender Notice

The Sr. Divisional Engineer/C, Northern Railway, DRM Office, Delhi Division, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055, for and on behalf of the President of India invites open electronic-tenders for under noted works:-

Name of work	Track works in connection with provision of Track Machine siding facilities at PKDE, MLDE, PHWR, KLE, SHDM, GKG and provision of RGM siding at KUN, RUG, RDE, KTF & NRWV in the section of Sr.DEN/1 & Sr. DEN/IV over Delhi Division. (Cost is inclusive of all taxes including GST)
Approximate cost of work	Rs. 5,69,84,838.05
Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs. 4,34,900/-
Completion period	12 Months
Date of opening	07.04.2026

The e-tender is to be submitted through railway website '<https://www.ireps.gov.in>'. The tenders can be submitted on website up to 15:00 hrs. on 07.04.2026 and shall be opened there after. No.: 128-W/Sr.DEN-C/NIT-17-25-26-WC Date: 13.03.2026 867/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.U/s 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Gillin @ Geelin S/o Mani Lal R/o H.No. E-678, 1st Floor, Sawda JJ Colony, Delhi** Also at- H. No. G-765, JJ Colony Sawda Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 99/2023 U/s 420/34 IPC PS: IP Estate Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Gillin @ Geelin** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Gillin @ Geelin** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Gillin @ Geelin** accused of **FIR No. 99/2023 U/s 420/34 IPC PS: IP Estate Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Preeti
JMFC-03, Room No. 150
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/2891/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C / 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Amar Jha, S/o. Shambu Jha, R/o.: J-937, Ground Floor, Jhahangir Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **E-FIR No.0493/2021 U/S 379/411 IPC** registered at **P.S Mahendra Park, North West District, Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said accused **Amar Jha** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Amar Jha** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Amar Jha**, accused of **FIR No. E-FIR No.0493/2021 U/S 379/411 IPC, P.S Mahendra Park, North West District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **16.04.2026**.

By Order, Ms. Amardeep Kaur
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (North)
Room No.117, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3351/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Dinesh Kumar Mandal, S/o Surya Narayan R/o A-120, (Dinesh Ka Makan), In front of Sarai Kale Khan, Sunlight Colony, Delhi** also at Vill. Bharat Patti Post Kalvahi PS Kalvahi Distt. Madhubani Bihar has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.5261/21 u/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Sunlight Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Dinesh Kumar Mandal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Dinesh Kumar Mandal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Dinesh Kumar Mandal of FIR No.5261/21 u/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Sunlight Colony, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **18.04.2026**.

By Order,
Aditi Rao
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07, South-East District
DP/3176/SE/2026 Room No.508, Saket Court-Complex, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ankit Sharma S/o Rishi Kumar R/o House No. C-2/1197, Sector-27, Rohini, Delhi (2) Raju S/o Rampal R/o Jhuggi, Near Hanuman Mandir, Bengali Colony, Shahbad, Daulatpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 104/2015 U/S 307/324/326/34 IPC, PS Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Ankit Sharma (2) Raju** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Ankit Sharma (2) Raju** has absconded (or is concealing Themself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ankit Sharma (2) Raju of FIR No. 104/2015 U/s 307/324/326/34 IPC, PS Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **29.04.2026**

By Order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class- 05, North
Court Room No. 114, First Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3213/ON/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Sumit Sharma, R/o: I-2/20, Sec-16 Rohini, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Ct No. 5729/18, U/s: 138 NI Act **PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Sumit Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Sumit Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Sumit Sharma of Ct No. 5729/18, U/s: 138 NI Act PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.04.2026**.

By Order
Amardeep Kaur
Additional Chif Judicial Magistrate
(North)/ Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/3156/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Gainda Lal S/o Rati Ram R/o H. No. E-2/3, Nand Nagri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 185/2019, U/s 33 Delhi Ex. Act, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Gainda Lal** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Gainda Lal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Gainda Lal of Case FIR No. 185/2019, U/s 33 Delhi Ex. Act, PS Nand Nagri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **23.04.2026**

By Order
Deepakshi Rana
Ld. Metropolitan Magistrate-03
Room No. 19, North-East Distt.
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/3276/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.PC/84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Manoj @ Kaku S/o Brijmohan @ Dina R/o H. No. 760, Gali Kunde Walan, Ajmeri Gate, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 297/2025, U/s 118(2)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita Act, Date 14.09.2025, PS Hauz Qazi, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Manoj @ Kaku** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Manoj @ Kaku** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Manoj @ Kaku of case FIR No. 297/2025 U/s 118(2)/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita Act, Date 14.09.2025, PS Hauz Qazi, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **30.04.2026**

By Order
Mansi Malik
ACJM-02, Central
Room No. 296A, 2nd Floor
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/3260/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

‘ONE BATTLE AFTER ANOTHER’

triumphs at 98th Academy Awards



The ceremony also saw Michael B Jordan win ‘Best Actor’ and ‘Sinners’ cinematographer Autumn Durald Arkapaw make Oscar history as the first female director of photography to win the award

Paul Thomas Anderson’s ‘One Battle After Another’ was crowned ‘Best Picture’ at the 98th Academy Awards, handing Hollywood’s top honour to a comic, multi-generational American saga of political resistance. The ceremony, which also saw Michael B Jordan win ‘Best Actor’ and ‘Sinners’ cinematographer Autumn Durald Arkapaw make Oscar history as the first female director of photography to win the award, was a long-incoming coronation for Anderson, a San Fernando Valley native who made his first short at age 18 and has been one of America’s most lionised filmmakers for decades. Before Sunday, Anderson had never won an Oscar.

But ‘One Battle After Another’, the favourite coming in, won six Oscars, including ‘Best Director’ and ‘Best Adapted Screenplay’ for Anderson, the Oscars’ first trophy for ‘Best Casting’ and ‘Best Supporting Actor’ for an absent Sean Penn.

“I wrote this movie for my kids to say sorry for the housekeeping mess that we left in this world - we’re handing off to them. But also, with the encouragement that they will be the generation that hopefully brings us some common sense and decency,” said Anderson while accepting the screenplay trophy. Ryan Coogler’s Jim Crow-set, blues-soaked vampire tale ‘Sinners’, which came in with a record 16 nominations, also landed some big and even historic wins. Coogler, the widely loved filmmaker, won the first Oscar in an unblemished career that started out with Jordan in 2013’s ‘Fruitvale Station’.

Arkapaw was also the first Black person to win for ‘Best Cinematography’. Only the fourth female cinematographer ever nominated, her win was a long-awaited triumph for women behind the camera. “I really want all the women in the room to stand up. Because I don’t feel like I get here without you guys,” said

Arkapaw. And Jordan, one of Hollywood’s most liked leading men, won ‘Best Actor’ in one of the night’s closest races. The Dolby Theatre rose to its feet to the most thunderous applause of the night. “Yo, momma, what’s up?” said Jordan after staggering to the stage. The Oscar night belonged to ‘Warner Bros’, the studio of ‘One Battle After Another’ and ‘Sinners’, which scored a record-breaking 11 wins. It was an oddly poignant note of triumph for the fabled studio, which weeks earlier agreed to a sale to ‘Paramount Skydance’, David Ellison’s rapidly assembled media monolith. The USD 111 billion deal, which awaits regulatory approval, has Hollywood bracing for more layoffs.

But ‘Sinners’ and ‘One Battle After Another’ - the much-acclaimed heavyweights of the season - were each Hollywood anomalies: big-budget originals born from a per-

Jessie Buckley won ‘Best Actress’ for her performance as Agnes Shakespeare in ‘Hamnet’, making her the first Irish performer to ever win in the category

sonal vision. In a year where anxiety over studio contraction and the rise of artificial intelligence often consumed the industry, both films gave Hollywood fresh hope. Jessie Buckley won ‘Best Actress’ for her performance as Agnes Shakespeare in ‘Hamnet’, making her the first Irish performer to ever win in the category. At an Oscars where no other acting award seemed a sure

thing, Buckley cruised into Sunday’s Oscars at the Dolby Theatre as the overwhelming favourite. “It’s Mother’s Day in the UK. I would like to dedicate this to the beautiful chaos of a mother’s heart,” said Buckley on the stage. From the start, when host Conan O’Brien sprinted through the year’s nominees as Amy Madigan’s character in the horror thriller ‘Weapons’ in a pre-taped bit, Sunday’s ceremony was quirky, a little clunky and preoccupied with the shifting place of movies in culture. There was, of all things, a tie for best live-action short film.

As expected, the ‘Netflix’ sensation ‘KPop Demon Hunters’, 2025’s most-watched film, won ‘Best Animated Feature’, as well as ‘Best Song’ for ‘Golden’. It was a big win for ‘Netflix’ but a more qualified victory for the movie’s producer, ‘Sony

Pictures’ - though it developed and produced the film, ‘Sony’ sold ‘KPop Demon Hunters’ to the streaming giant instead of giving it a theatrical release. On Netflix, ‘KPop Demon Hunters’ became a cultural phenomenon and the streaming platform’s biggest hit. It has more than 325 million views and counting. “This is for Korea and Koreans everywhere,” said co-director Maggie Kang. Another ‘Netflix’ release, Guillermo del Toro’s ‘Frankenstein’ picked up three awards for its lavish craft, for costume design, makeup and hair-styling and for production design. Amy Madigan won ‘Best Supporting Actress’ for her performance in ‘Weapons’, a win that came 40 years after she was first nominated in 1986 for ‘Twice in a Lifetime’.



‘I also feel like taking a break’

Shreya Ghoshal shared her thoughts on Arijit Singh’s move

After Arijit Singh’s decision to step away from playback singing sparked discussion among fans, Shreya Ghoshal shared her thoughts on the singer’s move and the importance of authenticity in live performances. Speaking in an interview with ‘ABP News’, Shreya said performing live is central to who she is as an artist. The singer stressed that lip-syncing on stage is something she would never want to rely on. “I feel very uncomfortable with that. I will stop singing the day I have to do that,” she said, adding that as long as her voice supports her and she continues her ‘riyaz’, she prefers to stand on stage and sing live for audiences. Reacting to Arijit Singh’s recent decision to step away from playback singing for films, Shreya said she respects the courage it takes to make such a choice. “I also feel

like taking a break sometimes. He took that decision very bravely,” she said. She also described Arijit as someone deeply connected to music. “He is a musician from the heart. He doesn’t think about why he is making music or what he will get from it. He does what makes him happy,” she added. Shreya said Arijit’s sincerity toward music is one of the reasons audiences connect with him so strongly. “For him, music is bigger than everything else and that’s why people love him so much,” she noted. Arijit Singh’s journey in Bollywood has been marked by several

chart-topping songs, making him one of the most loved playback singers of the past decade. Talking about stage performances, Shreya said artists have a responsibility toward the people who come to watch them. “As entertainers, what we are going through personally should not show on stage. People come to us for music and inspiration. Music heals them and helps them escape from their problems,” she said. Shreya added that the love she receives from audiences continues to motivate her to perform. “When your heart is happy, the energy comes automatically,” she said.

She said performing live is central to who she is as an artist

‘Want to make a film with Deepika, Alia & Sai’

Filmmaker Ashwiny Iyer Tiwari, known for her middle-of-the-road movies like ‘Nil Battey Sannata’ and ‘Bareilly Ki Barfi’, said if she gets to direct a big-budget multi-crore movie, her dream cast would be Deepika Padukone, Alia Bhatt and Sai Pallavi. Iyer Tiwari questioned why such ‘event films’ are predominantly done by male directors. “Why can’t a woman make a Rs 100 or Rs 1,000 crore film? Why does only a male director have to make? I have one in the house (her director husband, Nitesh Tiwari, known for ‘Dangal’ and the upcoming ‘Ramayana’) but still,” the director told PTI in an interview on the sidelines of Red Lorry Film Festival. Iyer Tiwari said she has a creative vision for it, but getting the backing from a studio is most crucial. “I just put it out there into the universe (about her desire to make a Rs 1,000 crore film) because you need a kind of platform, budget and everything is there. I may have an idea today, but if the studio is putting in money, then they also need to have that much faith and a long-term plan on it. So, it’s a two-way process,” she said. The director said that for her Rs 1,000 crore film, the actors on her wish-list are Deepika Padukone, Alia Bhatt and Sai Pallavi.



‘Battle of Galwan’ gets retitled as ‘Maatrubhumi’

The new title is likely inspired by the film’s first track, ‘Maatrubhumi’, sung by Arijit Singh

NEW DELHI: Bollywood superstar Salman Khan said his upcoming film ‘Battle of Galwan’ has been renamed as ‘Maatrubhumi’. The much-anticipated film is based on the 2020 Galwan Valley conflict between India and China and it is directed by Apoorva Lakhia of ‘Shootout at Lokhandwala’ fame. The actor didn’t provide any reason for the sudden name change of the movie. The movie now also carries the tagline, ‘May War Rest in Peace’. The new title is likely inspired by the film’s first track, ‘Maatrubhumi’, sung by Arijit Singh. “May War Rest in Peace. #Maatrubhumi,” Salman wrote in the captions of the film’s poster, carrying the new title. The film is inspired by the military standoff in eastern Ladakh in May 2020. Clashes at the Galwan Valley in June that year resulted in a severe strain in ties between India and China. 20 Indian Army personnel laid down their lives in the Galwan Valley clashes. In February 2021, China officially acknowledged that five Chinese military officers and soldiers were killed in the clashes. However, it is widely believed that the death toll on the Chi-



The much-anticipated film is based on the 2020 Galwan Valley conflict between India and China



nese side was much higher. Khan essays the role of Bikkumalla Santosh Babu, who laid down his life along with 19 other soldiers of the 16 Bihar Regiment during the clash. On Khan’s 60th birthday in December last year, he shared the teaser of the

film, which drew criticism from China’s Global Times. The newspaper claimed the movie to be a cinematic exaggeration and blamed it for distorting facts. A government source at the time said, “India has a tradition of cinematic expression. A movie titled

‘Haqeeqat’ was made in 1964 and the theme was the India-China war of 1962. Another film ‘120 Bahadur’ was made recently on the legendary battle of Rezang La. Cinemas are an artistic expression and India does not restrict them.”